Sun Tzu

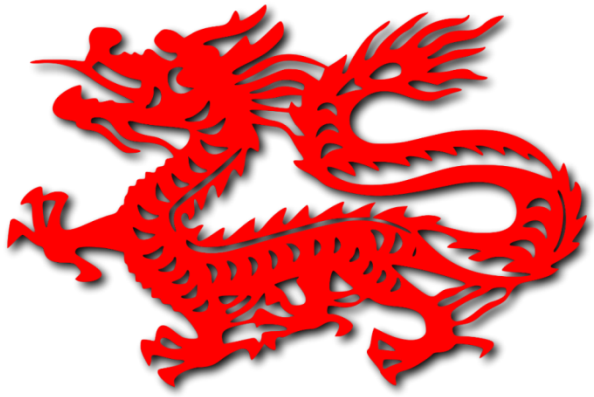
THE ART OF WAR

Concise Human Resources Applications



M. Amr Sadik

Sun Tzu
The Art of War
孫子兵法



Concise Human Resources Applications

By

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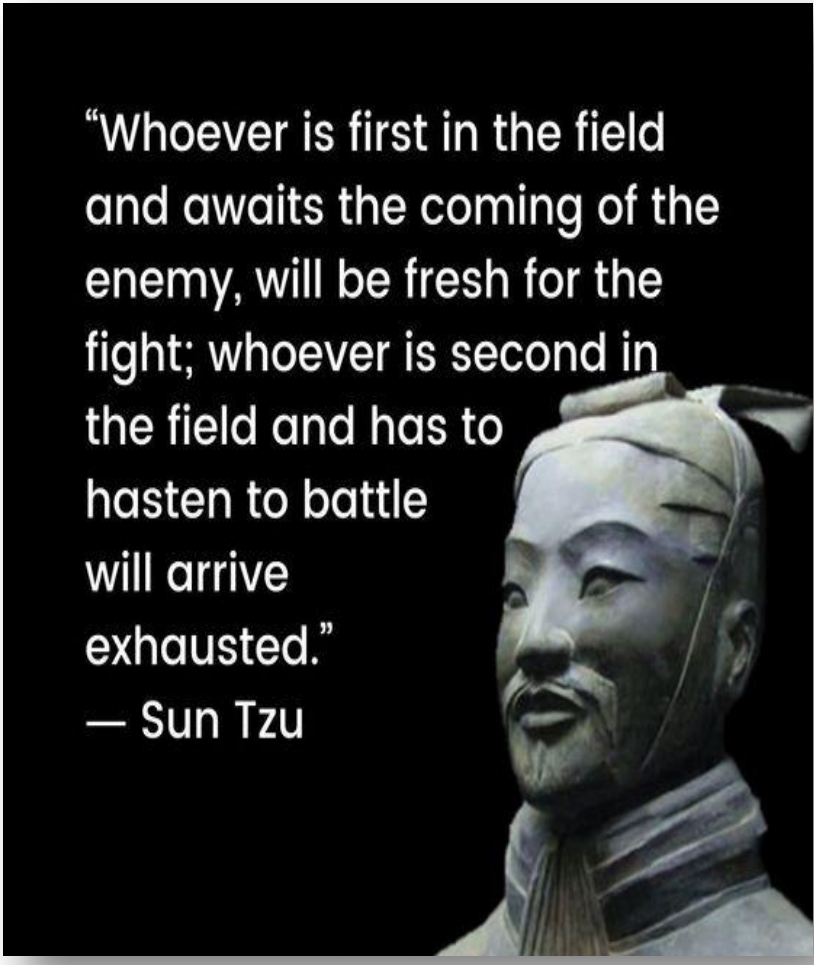
Dedication

I'd like to dedicate this book to all those who would love to learn from history, as those who fail to learn from the mistakes of their predecessors are destined to repeat them.

This book is for those who want to compete without losing and win their battles and those passionate about Human Resources and determined to excel in their careers.

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“Whoever is first in the field
and awaits the coming of the
enemy, will be fresh for the
fight; whoever is second in
the field and has to
hasten to battle
will arrive
exhausted.”
— Sun Tzu

(I) Preface

We all know that the history of personnel management begins around the end of the 19th century. During this time the focus was on the welfare of laborers in the organizations. But during 1914 – 1939 the 1st World War , many organizations showed quick growth and quick changes in the needs and wants of the operations. Therefore, the tasks done by women shifted to the men , because of the complexity of tasks. These officers were called "Labor Managers" at that time.

During the 1920s, jobs with the titles of ''labor manager'' or ''employment manager'' came into being in the engineering industry and other industries where there were large factories to handle absence, recruitment, dismissal ,queries over bonuses, and so on. Employers' federations, particularly in engineering and shipbuilding, negotiated national pay rates with the unions, but there were local and district variations and plenty of scope for disputes.

During the 1930s, with the economy beginning to pick up, big corporations in these newer sectors saw value in improving employee benefits as a way of recruiting, retaining ,and motivating employees. But older industries such as textiles, mining ,and shipbuilding,which were hit by the worldwide recession, did not

adopt new techniques, because they had no difficulty in recruiting labor.

The Second World War brought about welfare and personnel work on a full-time basis at all establishments producing war materials because an expanded Ministry of Labor and National Service insisted on it, just as the government had insisted on welfare employees in munitions factories in the previous conflict. The government saw specialist personnel management as part of the drive for greater efficiency and the number of people in the personnel function grew substantially; there were around 5,300 in 1943.

By 1945, employment management and welfare work had become integrated under the broad term ‘‘personnel management.’’ Experience of the war had shown that output and productivity could be influenced by employment policies. The role of the personnel function in wartime had been largely that of implementing the rules demanded by large-scale, state-governed production, and thus the image of an emerging profession was very much a bureaucratic one.

In the 1960s and 70s employment started to develop significantly. At the same time personnel techniques developed using theories from the social sciences about motivation and organizational behavior; selection testing became more widely used, and management training expanded. During the 1970s, specialisms

started to develop, with reward and resourcing, for example, being addressed as separate issues.

Around the mid-80s, the term ‘‘human resources management’’ arrived in the USA. The term ‘‘human resources’’ is an interesting one: it seemed to suggest that employees were an asset or resource-like machine, but at the same time, HR also appeared to emphasize employee commitment and motivation. But the fact is that Human Resources Management has ancient roots that ought to be revealed.

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We all have studied history in schools, read history books, watched history movies in cinemas, discussed the events and are impressed and fascinated by the heroes , their characters, and how they win their battles.

Who are the great ancient and/or contemporary leaders who have inspired us to follow them? Is it Sun Tzu, Attila, Hitler, Genghis Khan, Drucker, Jack Welch, or Alexander the Great?

Ancient history has many examples of personnel management in action. As far back as 1750 BC, the code of laws proclaimed by Hammurabi, King of Babylon, set wages for people hired as agricultural laborers, ox drivers and shepherds. Craftsmen could be prosecuted if they failed to pass their skills on to apprentices, builders were held liable for the standard of their work, and owners were required to pay for the health care of their slaves.

Many of the early examples are concerned with employees' health. In the 1st century AD, a Roman scholar, Pliny the Elder, warned about the hazards of handling zinc and sulfur and described a protective mask made from an animal's bladder, which protected laborers from dust and lead fumes. In 1473, Ulrich Ellenbog wrote a pamphlet on occupational diseases and injuries to gold miners. The field of occupational health further advanced in 1556, when the German scholar Agricola, described diseases that affected miners and prescribed preventative measures.

This book reveals the ancient history of HRM that Sun Tzu wrote in his masterpiece work *The Art of War*,2500 years ago.

Knowledge of the past or modern history of any subject is necessary to understand where the subject came from, where it is now, and where it is going. Some forms of management have existed since the beginning of time. Ever since, one human tried to direct another, management thought has been developing.

The Inception

The history of Human Resources Management did not begin at the time when academic professors published their books about Human Resources. They have just discovered the importance of it for successful organizations, but people management was crucial even in ancient times. The HR history is about the evolution of the first communes and the growth of the first ancient societies.

Unsurprisingly, the development of modern Human Resources Management practices comes with the military. The army was the first driver of innovations.

A nation without a strong army was invaded by neighbors highlighting the importance of a strong army visible to every citizen.

A successful command required strong, brave ,and smart leaders who engage and share a vision of victory. It designed and developed the first procedures for the outstanding selection of new hires and leaders. It had the resources to invest in innovations.

The first successful HR practices in history can be found in ancient armies. History can offer countless insights for HR leaders trying to navigate their challenges.

Why This Book is Different?

First of all, most of the available HR books are about the theory and practice of HR functions and are written by consultants and academics, but books about the HR profession that HR practitioners wrote are very rare. But this book is written by an HR practitioner for HR practitioners.

Secondly, this book is dedicated to HR executives who would like to learn about ancient HR practices that can be applied in their organizations to win the current business war. Here, Sun Tzu's ancient principles of war are reinterpreted for the current HR

executives. It offers the skills to gain a competitive advantage over the competitors.

HR leaders are everywhere, here and there, and that is the intention of this book to provide readers with some useful insights into what others have done in people management and what can we learn from them.

It is my sincere hope that readers will find this book easy to read and implement as well as inspiring.

Enjoy reading!

M. Amr Sadik

Cairo, 2024

(II) Introduction

In December 2015, I had an interview with my associate Alan Hosking, Publisher of HR Future Magazine in South Africa, explaining why HR professionals can learn much from reading Sun Tzu's ancient writings in *The Art of War*.

Why are you suggesting we look at the writings of Sun Tzu's The Art of War ,which was written in 500 BC?

History provides us with collective wisdom and experience to learn from. There is no doubt that ancient stories and history books shed light on different events and situations that happened in the past, which are to a great extent similar to events and situations in our present day. Such history can teach us many lessons that we can put into practice today in managing complex organizations and their human capital. Learning lessons from history has been a phenomenal source of free advice and inspiration.

Thus, those who fail to learn the lessons from history are condemned to repeat them, but the most significant thing we learn from history is that we certainly do not learn from it.

But what can military history say to practitioners and business leaders?

Military history has provided several useful representations for business, general management ,and human resources management

as well. To learn from military history, past events must be examined thoroughly so proper modules can be derived from them.

Over the past years, military descriptions have been used frequently in management topics such as Marketing, the Cola Wars – the story of the global corporate battle between the Coca-Cola Company and PepsiCo, Inc., and between fast food dynasties McDonald's and KFC. Everyone is trying to one-up each other amid intense competition. Also, in 1997, McKinsey and Company introduced the term "War for Talent" to describe the shortage of skills in the labor markets, which became part of Human Resources' annual planning activities to attract and retain the most talented staff.

To this end, certain comparisons can be made between company competitions and military warfare:

- Both strive for a winning position by defeating their competitors while defending themselves;
- Competitions and wars are confrontational activities;
- Organizations must be well organized and well managed;
- Organizations and wars require strategies and tactics;
- Leadership styles of both army and organization have an important influence on the shaping of success;
- Both need high-quality and committed people;
- Both thrive on information;
- Both have to have discipline and communication systems to convey the news and information;

- Both have to ensure the strong management of people.

With this in mind, we should be able to expand on those aspects of business that more closely resemble war – business competition and competitiveness. But, we will focus on the management of people's part.

Why choose a military man? Why not someone like a philosopher?

Sun Tzu and his book ,*The Art of War* , offer valuable insights into HR Management in the modern business environment. The book was based on military strategies, but in reality, these strategies can be used in all job fields, such as Human Resources. His writings have been highly influential in both marketing and business management science.

In his writings, he also shed light on some essential principles for HR to follow. HR practitioners ought to go through Sun Tzu's philosophies to appreciate his clear wisdom and the clarity of thought that we can put into practice, as some of the noticeable concepts that are embedded in his works can be applied to Human Resources Management.

Sun Tzu said,

"***The art of war is of vital importance to the State. It is a matter of life and death, a road either to safety or to ruin. Hence, it is a subject of inquiry which can on no account be neglected.***"

In the contemporary management as well as in the HR business environment, achieving a competitive advantage is done by and through people as they are the unique source that cannot be copied easily. But other sources can.

Therefore, from an HR point of view,

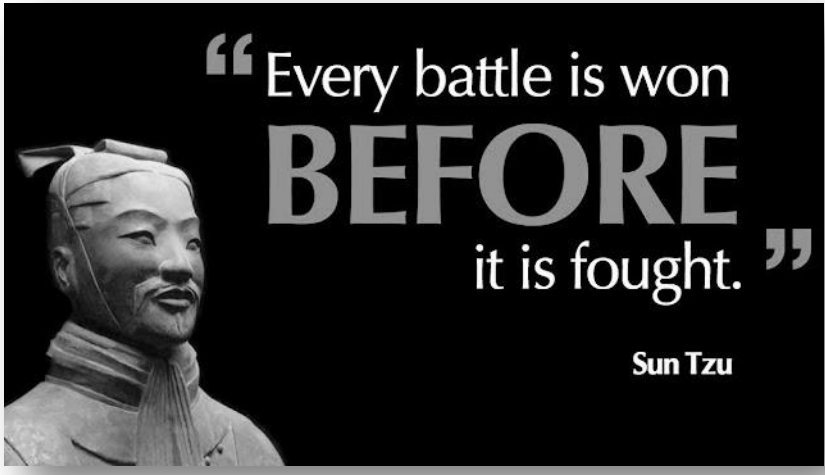
"***The art of managing people is of vital importance to an organization, it is a matter of life and death, a road either to prosperity and competitiveness or to destruction and bankruptcy, hence, it is a subject of inquiry, which can on no account be neglected.***"

*****

I came to know about Sun Tzu in the late nineties, when my inspirer General Manager, **Mr. *Peter Alatsas***, at Sheraton Hotel & Villas, conducted a seminar session on "*The Art of War as Marketing Applications.*"

Thus, I became a reader and fan of Sun Tzu's writings and later on, decided to come up with this concise book as an interpretation of his strategies on People Management.

Seeing HR through different eyes will give you a new perspective on its role in the organization.


“Every battle is won
BEFORE
it is fought.”
Sun Tzu

(II) Who is Sun Tzu?

China has always been a fertile land of great thinkers. Most of those philosophers were concerned not with metaphysical quests but with finding ways to live a correct life in society. No wonder they excelled in sociology, psychology, ethics, and the organization of society. They devoted themselves to searching for, examining ,and then prescribing ways of establishing a harmonious and orderly social life.

Sun Tzu lived in the state of Qi around 500 BC. Tzu was a respectful title that people in the Chou Dynasty (11th century–255 BC) used to address philosophers. It can be translated as "professor" or "master".



At that time, China was divided into numerous states engaged in virtually perpetual warfare. It was a time of chaos, with constant conflicts and upheavals. This period in Chinese history is known as the Warring States (475–221 BC).

It was also during this time that a group of scholars with expertise in the conduct of war and the organization of the state traveled around the country, offering their advice to those rulers who were willing to pay for their services.

They were the first consultants in history. Among them, Confucius (Kong Zi in Chinese) was undoubtedly the most famous. Sun Tzu belongs to the same category of philosopher-consultant.

Paradoxically, this time of social confusion and the decay of public institutions was also a golden age for China, a time of splendor in arts and philosophy. Among the many thinkers of the time, Sun Tzu is one of the few masters whose work has survived. Even today, 2,500 years later, his treatise *The Art of War* is still published and widely consulted.

The Art of War is the first practical book on how to manage armies and conduct wars. It is also one of the few masterpieces of antiquity that you can still find in any bookshop in the world.

However, the question is how a work about military strategy written so many years ago can be relevant to contemporary management.

It is said that when Ho-Lu, the king of the state of Wu, read *The Art of War*, he called Sun Tzu to his palace. The king wanted to test the effectiveness of his ideas. Sun Tzu accepted the challenge without any hesitation. He asked permission to use the king's concubines for an exercise with the condition that the king must respect Sun Tzu's decisions. The king agreed to this.

Sun Tzu divided the women into two groups and selected the king's two favorite concubines to be the commanders. He explained to them the main elements of military exercises. When he finished his explanations, Sun Tzu asked whether or not they had understood the rules. All the women answered affirmatively. However, when Sun Tzu started to give orders, all the women roared with laughter. Sun Tzu said: "If the regulations are not clear and orders are not thoroughly understood, it is the commander's fault."

He then repeated the instructions once more. When he gave orders for the second time, the women again burst into laughter.

This time, Sun Tzu said: "If the regulations have been sufficiently explained but are not carried out, it is the fault of the officers." Then he ordered the two concubines to be beheaded. On hearing this, the king hurriedly told the master that he had perfectly understood his system ,so it was not necessary.

But Sun Tzu did not accept his pleading and went on with the executions. After that, he appointed two other women as company commanders and continued the exercises.

This time, when Sun Tzu repeated his orders, no one dared to laugh, and the military exercises were in strict accordance with his instructions. Meanwhile, the king was so depressed by the loss of his two beloved concubines that he had no more interest in viewing the exercises. So, Sun Tzu said to him: “Your Highness likes words but has no courage to carry them out.”

Reinterpret Sun Tzu’s military text in the context of modern management and derive guidance for addressing contemporary challenges. For example, the military terms such as army, terrain, enemy, and commander used in the treatise are replaced with business terms such as organization, environment, competitor, and leader.

(III) Who You Are?

Sun Tzu said,

"***If you know the enemy and know yourself, you need not fear the result of a hundred battles. If you know yourself but not the enemy, for every victory gained you will also suffer a defeat. If you know neither the enemy nor yourself, you will succumb in every battle***."

For practitioners to excel, it is of utmost importance to know ***Who they really are.***

To identify your quest of a lifetime. The great philosopher Socrates said it himself, "***To know thyself is the beginning of wisdom***."

Knowing yourself is about knowing what makes you tick. It means identifying what matters to you, your strengths and weaknesses, your behaviors, tendencies, and thought patterns. The more you know about yourself and the reasons for your preferences and actions, the more you know about others. Self-knowledge breeds a universe of knowledge about human dynamics.

Knowledge of your preferences can be obtained by thinking about the people with whom you associate most comfortably. Often, they have the same personality preferences and arrive at decisions in the same manner as you do. Looking at your closest friends can provide a mirror image of yourself.

There are a few steps through which you can discover yourself. Some of you can get through them in a few days, and for some others, it may take weeks or even months. If you have never really thought about your life and passion as having a mission and purpose, it will take you longer.

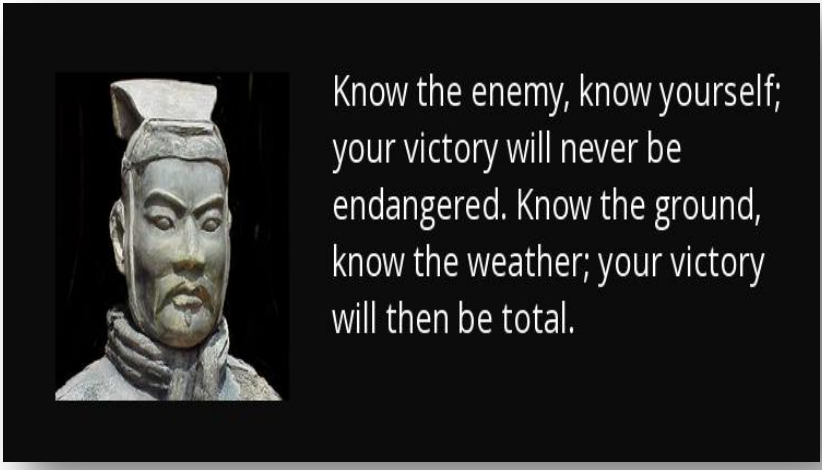
No matter where you are in terms of self-awareness and whether or not you know your true purpose in life, these steps will prove invaluable in your search for a better life and a better you. Let's take a closer look at what you have to do:

- **Take Personality Assessment**: Our ability to identify ourselves is apparent in the administration of the widely used personality test, the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator.
- **Find Your Passion:** What parts of your previous jobs and your current life are consistent with your passion?
- **Define Success:** Is the only term that matters to you.
- **Set Goals:** Set SMART goals around every area of your life, and write them down.
- **Think:** Post your goals and read them daily. Your defined and positive thoughts will begin to shape your daily actions, which in turn will lead to your successful future.
- **Operate with Integrity:** Know that your personal and professional lives are intertwined and that you cannot live these two aspects of your life separately. Choose to operate both with character and surround yourself with people and professional endeavors that aim to do the same. Know that

every word you speak has an impact on your life and plan to spend your time in ways that have a positive impact on yourself and others.

- **Execute:** Lay out a plan that helps move you towards your goals. Remember that your passion and goals will sustain you through the hard times, and understand that failure and quitting are NOT options. Execution is not the hardest part of this program, knowing WHAT to execute on is actually where most people fail.
- **Give back:** Success, when measured by what you alone achieve will never sustain you long-term , nor will it enable you to give back. Start now by giving out a smile when you can, a helping hand, and realize you are planting the seeds of giving in your life which will enable you to look back on a long life and feel it was well lived. We all have something to give, no matter what our present circumstances.

In your quest for personal success, you have to make decisions. You won't always make the right ones along the way ,but strong relationships can help you overcome setbacks en route to your goals.


Know the enemy, know yourself; your victory will never be endangered. Know the ground, know the weather; your victory will then be total.

Chapter-1
Staffing Principle

Staffing any organization today is a challenging, complex endeavor. Economic changes, demographic shifts, increased multiculturalism, heightened global competition, organizational restructuring,extended legislation, and a host of other factors suggest that this activity will be even more crucial in the years to come.

Staffing is broadly defined as the process of attracting, selecting, and retaining competent individuals to achieve organizational goals. Every organization uses some form of staffing procedure, and staffing is the primary way an organization influences its diversity and human capital.

As organizations enter the current century, it is readily apparent that the acquisition and utilization of human resources are as vital to continued organizational success as the advanced technology required for producing products and providing services.

Indeed, technology alone is insufficient since effective use of it depends upon people—the right kinds of people, in the right numbers, performing the right jobs at the right times.

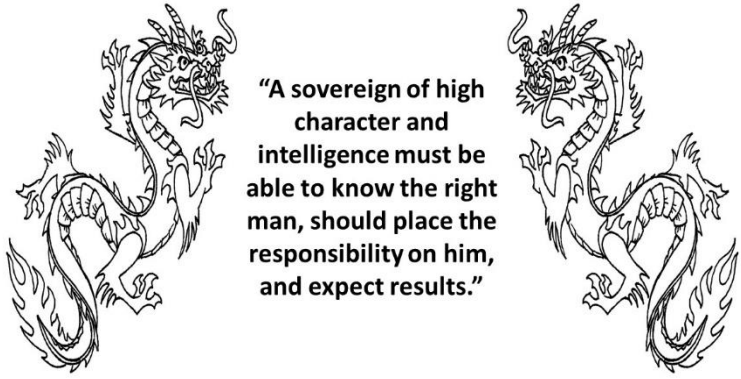
Whether in the past, present, or future, it is people—the catalytic resource of any institution—that has, do, and will determine organizational success.

Combining the broad definition of staffing with its objectives, we can define staffing more specifically as the process through which an organization ensures that it always has the proper number of employees with the appropriate skills in the right jobs at the right time to achieve the organization's objectives.

Sun Tzu said, "***A supreme of high character and intelligence must be able to know the right man, should place the responsibility on him, and expect results***."

What can be more important than finding and hiring the best people and then allowing them to realize their full potential?

The organization's ability to hire, develop ,and retain employees may be the single most critical determinant of organizational success in today's stiff competition.



Finding and appointing the right people is imperative, but providing them with the of staffing the organization is a critical task, particularly when it comes to hiring talent.

Selection is the process of choosing the right individuals with the right qualifications to fill jobs. Without such qualified employees, the organization's success is at stake.

In reality, the process of building a company with good to great employees starts with the hiring process.

HR practitioners who can manage the selection process for their organizations by hiring the right candidates the first time have a competitive edge.

In addition, when employees are matched with the right jobs, then the amount and quality of work is more positive.

Therefore, to staff your organizations with the right candidates, you need to think of defining the required skills, attracting the right people, and selecting the best person.

Sun Tzu's *The Art of War* is a classical Chinese text that primarily deals with military strategy and tactics. While it doesn't explicitly discuss modern staffing principles, many of its principles can be applied to various aspects of management and leadership, including staffing.

- **Know Your Personnel:** Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of understanding your soldiers, their strengths, weaknesses, and motivations. Similarly, in staffing, it's crucial to know

your employees— their skills, abilities, and preferences— to assign tasks effectively and foster a productive work environment.

- **Utilize Talent Wisely:** Sun Tzu stresses the importance of deploying troops according to their strengths and weaknesses. In staffing, this translates to assigning roles and responsibilities based on employees' skills and expertise to maximize productivity and efficiency.
- **Develop Your Team:** Sun Tzu emphasizes the need for training and preparation to ensure soldiers are well-prepared for battle. Similarly, in staffing, investing in employee development and training programs can enhance skills and competencies, leading to a more capable and motivated workforce.
- **Maintain Morale:** Sun Tzu highlights the significance of morale in warfare, stating that it can turn the tide of battle. In staffing, maintaining employee morale through recognition, rewards, and a positive work environment can improve productivity, retention, and overall organizational success.
- **Adaptability:** Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of adaptability and flexibility in response to changing circumstances. Similarly, in staffing, being able to adjust staffing levels, roles, and strategies in response to business needs and market conditions is essential for success.
- **Effective Communication:** Sun Tzu stresses the importance of clear communication and information sharing among

troops. In staffing, effective communication between practitioners and employees, as well as among team members, is crucial for coordination, collaboration, and goal achievement.

- **Strategic Deployment:** Sun Tzu discusses the strategic deployment of troops to gain a tactical advantage. In staffing, strategically deploying employees to projects or tasks where their skills are most needed can optimize performance and outcomes.

Although, *The Art of War* does not directly address modern staffing principles, its timeless wisdom and strategic insights can still be applied to effectively manage and lead teams in various organizational contexts.

Chapter-2
Culture Principle

Organizational culture refers to the shared values, beliefs, attitudes, norms, and behaviors that characterize an organization and guide its members in their interactions and decision-making processes. It is the personality or identity of the organization that influences how individuals within the organization perceive and respond to various situations.

Key components of organizational culture include:

Values: The core principles and beliefs that guide the organization's actions and decisions. These values are often communicated through mission statements or corporate philosophies.

Norms: The unwritten rules or expectations that dictate acceptable behavior within the organization. Norms may include things like dress code, communication styles, and work hours.

Symbols: Objects, rituals, language, or stories that represent and reinforce the organization's culture. This could include company logos, annual events, or legends about the organization's history.

Leadership Style: The leadership approach adopted by top management sets the tone for the organization's culture. Leaders shape culture through their actions, communication, and decision-making.

Communication: How information flows within the organization can greatly influence its culture. Open and transparent communication fosters trust and collaboration, while secretive or selective communication can breed distrust and resentment.

Employee Behaviors: The collective actions and attitudes of employees shape the culture of the organization. Hiring practices, performance evaluations, and recognition systems all play a role in reinforcing desired behaviors.

Organizational Structure: The way the organization is structured can impact its culture. Hierarchical structures may promote stability and control, while flat structures may encourage innovation and collaboration.

A strong organizational culture can provide numerous benefits, including increased employee engagement, improved morale, greater organizational commitment, and enhanced productivity. However, if not managed effectively, organizational culture can also become a barrier to change or innovation or even foster toxic behaviors such as discrimination or harassment. Therefore, leaders should intentionally cultivate, and nurture a positive and healthy culture within their organizations.

Sun Tzu said, "*The Art of War*, then, is governed by five constant factors, to be taken into account in one's deliberations, when seeking to determine the conditions obtained in the field. These are: **(1) The Moral Law; (2) Heaven; (3) Earth; (4) The Commander; (5) Method and discipline.**"

(1) The Moral Law :

Moral law is defined in various dictionaries and literature as beliefs, values, or ethics followed by people in a society ,or community. In this interpretation, it refers to organizational culture and how people behave within an organization.

The "**Moral Law**" as explained by Sun Tzu means that a leader must win his/her people's hearts, making them think the same things as he does, so that they are willing to make sacrifices for him. It refers to the ethical and virtuous aspect of leadership and warfare, emphasizing the importance of legitimacy, righteousness, and the moral high ground in achieving victory.



In Sun Tzu's view, Moral Law encompasses several key principles:

Righteousness: Sun Tzu believed that a leader should have a just cause and moral legitimacy behind their actions. By upholding righteousness, a leader gains the support and loyalty of their

followers, which is crucial for maintaining unity and morale in times of conflict.

Ethical Conduct: Sun Tzu emphasized the importance of ethical behavior both on and off the battlefield. Leaders who act with integrity, honesty, and fairness earn the respect of their troops and inspire them to perform at their best ,and leaders who engage in deceit, cruelty, or betrayal risk losing the trust and support of their followers.

Lead by Example: Sun Tzu believed that leaders should set a moral example for their subordinates to follow. By demonstrating virtuous behavior and adhering to high ethical standards, leaders can inspire loyalty and discipline within their ranks.

Winning Hearts and Minds: Sun Tzu recognized the significance of psychological warfare and the importance of winning over the hearts and minds of both allies and enemies. By appealing to shared values, principles, and beliefs, a leader can sway public opinion, undermine the enemy’s morale, and ultimately achieve victory without resorting to unnecessary violence.

Legitimacy and Authority: Sun Tzu stressed the importance of having legitimate authority and moral legitimacy behind one's actions. Leaders who act in accordance with moral principles and gain the support of the people are more likely to succeed in their endeavors and maintain long-term stability and prosperity.

Overall, Sun Tzu believed that Moral Law is an essential component of effective leadership and warfare, enabling leaders to harness the power of righteousness, ethical conduct, and legitimacy to achieve their objectives with minimal conflict and maximum support from their followers.

*****

In business, leadership and organizational culture are closely related: the leader may influence organizational culture and vice versa. Organizational culture founded on values, beliefs, and norms that are embraced by leaders daily — in what they say and what they do — are those that will take root and remain.

Leaders who honor people's basic needs for health, security, recognition, belonging, and a sense of purpose in a manner that aligns with the cultural traits of an organization provide an environment that motivates and builds the organizational synergy required to breed success.

The culture institutes standards of tolerable behavior and an understanding of organizational operating styles. HR practitioners must be able to define organizational culture in order to be able to manage it.

As mentioned in *In Search of Excellence*, Peters ,and Waterman drew a lot of attention to the importance of culture in achieving high levels of organizational effectiveness. Such culture can be instigated in any HR activities such as recruitment, selection,

performance management, reward system, interpersonal communication ,and so forth.

The HR professional becomes the “de facto” agent of culture change. Therefore, how to develop a culture that benefits the development of an organization has become a very important issue for HR practitioners. HR plays a significant part in the process of embedding it and supporting leaders as they walk the talk.

*****

(2) Heaven

“**Heaven**” refers to the analysis of the market trend. Sun Tzu means the changes in times and seasons, such as night and day, rain and shine, and cold and heat, which, when broadly applied to business operations, may include the analysis of market changes and future development of business. Heaven represents the uncontrollable and unpredictable elements of the environment or circumstances that may affect the outcome of a conflict. It includes factors like weather, seasons, and other natural phenomena. Understanding and adapting to these external conditions are crucial for success.

Thus, if we apply Sun Tzu's principles and the concept of heaven to human resources, we would likely find a strategic and holistic approach to managing people and organizational dynamics in such a way:

Creating a Positive Work Environment: Fostering a workplace culture where employees feel valued, respected, and supported in their personal and professional growth. This could involve initiatives such as employee wellness programs, diversity and inclusion efforts, and opportunities for career advancement.

Promoting Ethical Leadership: Encouraging leaders to act with integrity, fairness, and compassion in their interactions with employees. This could involve training programs on ethical decision-making, accountability mechanisms, and promoting a culture of transparency and trust.

Supporting Employee Well-Being: Recognizing that employees are not just resources but individuals with physical, emotional, and spiritual needs. This could involve offering resources for mental health support, work-life balance initiatives, and promoting a sense of purpose and meaning in the workplace.

However, for HR, it means workforce trends, retention issues,war for talent, employee satisfaction, and any other issues that can affect directly or indirectly the composition of the workforce for an organization.

Combining Sun Tzu's strategic approach with the concept of heaven's ideals in HR could lead to a comprehensive and balanced approach to managing human capital, where the organization's goals are aligned with the well-being and fulfillment of its employees.

*****

(3) Earth

"**Earth**" equals the evaluation of environmental traffic. Sun Tzu's earth means great location, including the distance and convenience of traffic, height of location, and width of the store space. Sun Tzu stresses the significance of understanding the terrain thoroughly, including its advantages and disadvantages, in order to formulate effective strategies and tactics.

HR plays an important role in ensuring employee health and safety, as they know the workplace, the employees ,and their job demands by creating a healthy working environment by considering the physical conditions like lighting, heating ,and air-conditioning, as well as workplace safety to prevent and/or mitigate loss, risks to or from personnel, threats to its physical assets, damage to its technology and intellectual property, or risks of any other kind arising from all elements surrounding the work environment.

*****

(4) The Commander

The "**Commander**" signifies the criteria for recruiting talent. As mentioned earlier, Sun Tzu's commander equal leader who should possess five qualities – wisdom, sincerity, benevolence, courage ,and strictness. The leader's qualities, capabilities, and decision-making skills play a pivotal role in determining the outcome of military endeavors. Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of

competent leadership, strategic vision, adaptability, and the ability to inspire and command troops effectively.

As the competitive ability of a business comes from high-quality supervisors, finding excellent talent that matches the features, culture ,and job needs of the organization depends heavily on a sound recruiting system.

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(5) Method and discipline

"**Method and Discipline**" refer to the establishment of rules and regulations. By method and discipline, Sun Tzu means the establishing of the organizational structure and the allocation of rights and duties. It involves implementing efficient tactics, maintaining cohesion among troops, and adhering to a well-defined chain of command. Sun Tzu underscores the importance of rigorous training and discipline in achieving victory on the battlefield.

Therefore, creating coherence and harmony within the organization and making employees cooperate well with one another so as to manifest the values, beliefs ,and mission shared by group members becomes a necessity for successful HR practices.

Let's analyze how each of these factors can be applied to HRM:

The Moral Law:

In HRM, the moral law refers to ethical principles and values that guide organizational behavior. HR practitioners need to uphold

fairness, integrity, and respect in all aspects of their decision-making processes, including recruitment, promotion, and disciplinary actions. Adhering to ethical standards helps foster a positive work culture and enhances employee trust and loyalty.

Heaven:

In Sun Tzu's context, “Heaven” refers to external factors beyond human control. In HRM, this could represent the broader economic, political, and social environment in which organizations operate. HR professionals must stay updated on industry trends, labor laws, and economic conditions to anticipate changes that may impact workforce planning, talent acquisition, and organizational development strategies.

Earth:

“Earth” in Sun Tzu's philosophy signifies the physical and environmental conditions of the battlefield. In HRM, this could translate to the internal dynamics of the organization, including its structure, culture, and resources. HR practitioners must assess the organization's strengths and weaknesses, as well as potential barriers to employee productivity and engagement.

Understanding the earth enables HR to implement strategies that align with the company's objectives and values.

The Commander:

In HRM, the commander represents leadership within the organization. Effective HR leadership involves setting clear goals,

providing guidance and support to employees, and making strategic decisions that drive organizational success. HR leaders must possess strong interpersonal skills, emotional intelligence, and the ability to inspire and motivate their teams.

Method and Discipline:

Method and discipline encompass the strategies and processes employed to achieve objectives systematically. In HRM, this involves establishing and enforcing policies and procedures related to recruitment, performance management, training, and employee relations. Consistency and fairness in implementing these methods foster a culture of accountability and professionalism within the organization.

By integrating these principles into HRM practices, organizations can enhance their ability to attract, retain, and develop talent while achieving their strategic goals.

Chapter-3
Reward Principle

Rewarding principles in Human Resources encompass a variety of strategies and approaches aimed at incentivizing and recognizing employees for their contributions to an organization. These principles are crucial for fostering motivation, engagement, and retention among employees. Here are some key rewarding principles in HR:

Fairness and Equity: Rewards should be distributed fairly and equitably based on factors such as performance, skills, and contribution to the organization. Employees should perceive the reward system as just and impartial.

Performance-Based Rewards: Linking rewards to performance encourages employees to strive for excellence and aligns individual goals with organizational objectives. Performance metrics should be clear, measurable, and directly tied to rewards.

Recognition and Appreciation: Acknowledging employees' efforts and achievements through verbal praise, awards, or other forms of recognition boosts morale and reinforces positive behavior. Regular and sincere appreciation fosters a culture of appreciation within the organization.

Competitive Compensation: Offering competitive salaries and benefits is essential for attracting and retaining top talent. HR

should regularly benchmark compensation packages against industry standards to ensure they remain competitive.

Opportunities for Development: Providing opportunities for learning, growth, and career advancement is a valuable form of reward. Investing in employees' development through training programs, mentorship, and promotions demonstrates a commitment to their long-term success.

Flexible Rewards: Recognizing that different employees have diverse preferences and motivations, offering a range of rewards such as bonuses, promotions, flexible work arrangements, and non-monetary incentives allows HR to cater to individual needs and preferences.

Transparency and Communication: Clear communication about the organization's reward philosophy, criteria, and processes enhances employees' understanding of how rewards are determined. Transparency builds trust and ensures employees feel valued and informed.

Consistency and Predictability: Reward systems should be consistent and predictable to avoid perceptions of bias or favoritism. Employees should understand the criteria for rewards and trust that they will be applied consistently across the organization.

Continuous Feedback: Regular feedback on performance and opportunities for improvement are integral to a robust reward

system. Practitioners should provide constructive feedback to help employees understand their strengths and areas for development, thereby guiding them toward achieving their goals.

Alignment with Organizational Values: Rewarding behaviors and outcomes that align with the organization's values, mission, and objectives reinforce its culture and strategic priorities. Employees who exemplify these values should be recognized and rewarded accordingly.

By adhering to these rewarding principles, HR departments can create an effective and motivational reward system that not only recognizes employees' contributions but also drives performance and fosters a positive workplace culture.

*****

Sun Tzu said,

"***For them to perceive the advantage of defeating the enemy, they must also have their rewards***."

Rewards are necessary for the soldiers to see the advantage of defeating the enemy. Therefore, the Spoils of War must be used as rewards. In war, the spoils of the enemy might vary from supplies, food, weapons, ammunition, horses ,or any material item of value that is confiscated at the end of a battle. It is important to reward the troops to keep them engaged and motivated for the next battle.

Likewise, organizations have their spoils but in the form of profits, financial results ,and stocks that are gained from competing in the marketplace.



If a company has a successful year, wins new business ,and posts great financial results, the profits have to be used as rewards so that employees will have a keen desire to perform. If only the Executives earn the rewards, or the owners keep it, and the employees are continuously told there is no money left, there will be negative consequences. Engagement will drop, the quality of work will be impacted, and eventually, the people will lose any desire to win the next battle.

Employees will give their maximum when they feel that the management will reward their efforts, initiatives ,and performance. If employees are not rewarded for their performance, the only incentive is to avoid being punished for doing poorly. This is a great way to breed an apathetic and mediocre workforce. So give

them praise and encouragement. Share with them the spoils of war, and they will be ready to fight.

Thus, HR practitioners should create a reward system that recognizes employee performance and behavior. Performance is the easiest to address because of the direct link between the initial goals set by the organization for the employees and the final outcomes that result in Pay for Performance.

What about rewarding behavior?

In war, the victorious general should share the spoils of war with his men because it was by their effort and their sacrifice that victory was achieved, and in business too, board members, GMs, CEOs ,and/or owners must share the profits with their employees who were doing the actual work for them.

Sun Tzu's *The Art of War* does indeed discuss principles related to rewards .However, it does so within the broader context of strategy and leadership rather than specific reward systems, as we might think of them in modern organizational contexts.

- **Understanding Motivation:** Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of understanding what motivates your soldiers or team members. He suggests that by knowing their desires and fears, a leader can better incentivize them to perform effectively.
- **Use of Incentives:** Sun Tzu advocates for the strategic use of rewards and incentives to encourage desirable behavior. This

could include promises of promotions, recognition, or material rewards for successful performance.

- **Rewards and Punishments:** Sun Tzu suggests that leaders should balance rewards with punishments, using both to maintain discipline and motivation within the ranks. This echoes the idea that a leader should be both benevolent and strict, rewarding good behavior and punishing misconduct.
- **Recognition:** Sun Tzu stresses the importance of recognizing and rewarding individual achievements and contributions. By acknowledging the efforts of soldiers or team members, leaders can boost morale and inspire loyalty.
- **Leading by Example:** Sun Tzu believed that leaders should set an example for their followers. By demonstrating bravery, dedication, and other desirable traits, leaders can inspire their team members and create a culture where hard work and excellence are rewarded.
- **Adaptability in Rewards:** Sun Tzu emphasizes the need for flexibility in leadership and strategy. This includes being adaptable in the rewards offered to soldiers or team members, and tailoring incentives to suit the situation and the individuals involved.

Overall, while *The Art of War* doesn't provide a comprehensive framework for modern reward systems, it does offer timeless insights into human motivation and effective leadership, which can be applied to designing reward structures within organizations.

Thus, organizations that hope to reap the rewards of a committed, empowered workforce have to learn to stop kidding themselves and know that they will be out of business faster than they may think when their brains and muscles leave them and soon will be defeated in the war of business.

Chapter-4
Training Principle

The ability of organizations to adapt and learn to operate in changing circumstances are critical capabilities. Training and development are critical components of organizational success, impacting employee performance, satisfaction, and retention. Training in organizations is essential for fostering employee development, increasing productivity, maintaining competitiveness, and ensuring long-term success. It is a strategic investment that yields numerous benefits for both employees and the organization as a whole.

Perspectives of Training & Development

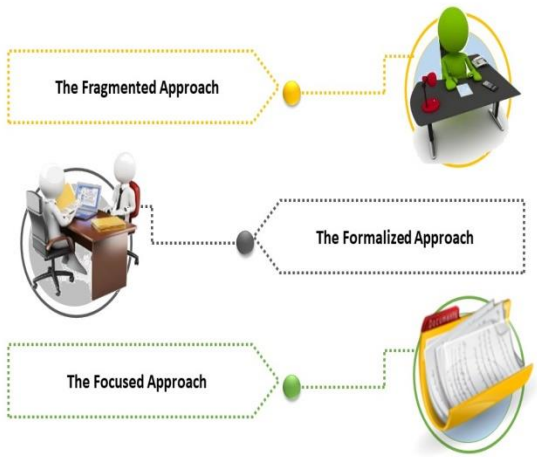


Figure 4.1 The three approaches to training.

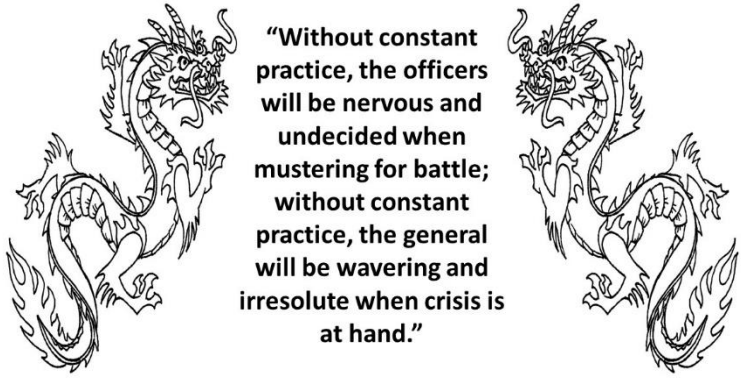
Fragmented Approach	*Formalized Approach*	*Focused Approach*
• Training is not linked or connected to organizational or hierarchical objectives. • Training is seen as an unnecessary extravagance. • Training is instructional and conveyed through trainers or instructors. • Non-systematic way to deal with training. • Concentrates on training and not improvement. • Knowledge or theory-based courses.	• Training is directly and straightforwardly connected to human resource needs. • Precise and systematic formative training linked and connected to appraisals. • Line Managers and Superiors are involved in development and contribute to the improvement of the course content. • Knowledge or theory-based courses expanded to aptitude-based. • Training is still conducted by trainers, however, the scope of aptitudes required increases. • Increased pre-and post-course activities and exercises.	• Training becomes a strategy and source of competitiveness and survival in the market. • Training helps to provide on-the-job advancement. • Individual is provided self-choice for specific instructional classes. • Training is non-directive except for knowledge-based instructional classes. • New types of training implementation techniques are investigated, for example, open courses and e-learning. • Measuring and estimating training results is critical to the association.

Sun Tzu said,

"***Without constant practice, the officers will be nervous and undecided when mustering for battle; without constant practice, the general will be wavering and irresolute when the crisis is at hand***."

In warfare, skilled troops establish positions that make them unbeatable and do not miss opportunities to attack what the enemy values most when they become vulnerable.

Similarly, organizations that don't have training programs may lose good employees who want to progress in their careers and consequently lose the competitive advantage or, if they try to retain good staff without investing in them, often end up being the loser in the war for talent.



Training and developing the workforce is not something to be taken lightly. It calls for the same rigorous approach to strategy, planning, and return on investment.

As Jeffrey Pfeffer mentioned in his book *Competitive Advantage through People*: *Unleashing the Power of the Work Force*, if competitive advantage has to be achieved by people, then the skills of those people are critical.

The writings of Sun Tzu in *The Art of War* offer tremendously valuable insights into the mental state needed to succeed in the management of the modern business and its human capital. Going through the art of war can help anyone reach and maintain success, whether in business, school, relationships ,or other things. So much knowledge could be taken from the history.

Sun Tzu's *The Art of War* provides timeless principles for strategic thinking and warfare, many of which can be applied to various aspects of life, including training and leadership.

- **Know Yourself and Your Enemies:** Understand your strengths, weaknesses, and capabilities as well as those of your opponents. In training, this translates to self-assessment and understanding the competition or challenges you face.
- **Preparation:** Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of thorough preparation before engaging in any conflict. In training, this means being well-prepared physically, mentally, and strategically for the tasks ahead.
- **Adaptability:** Sun Tzu advocates for flexibility and adaptability in response to changing circumstances. Training should include scenarios that challenge participants to adapt

quickly to new situations and adjust their strategies accordingly.

- **Discipline and Focus:** Discipline is crucial for success both in warfare and training. Maintaining focus on goals and objectives despite distractions or setbacks is essential.
- **Utilization of Resources:** Sun Tzu stresses the efficient use of resources, including time, manpower, and materials. In training, this means optimizing available resources to maximize effectiveness and productivity.
- **Unity of Command:** Clear leadership and communication are essential for effective training. Ensure that there is a unified command structure and clear lines of communication to prevent confusion and facilitate coordination.
- **Surprise and Deception:** Sun Tzu emphasizes the value of surprise and deception in gaining an advantage over opponents. In training, incorporating elements of surprise can keep participants engaged and simulate real-world scenarios.
- **Continuous Improvement:** Sun Tzu encourages continuous learning and improvement. After each training session, evaluate performance, identify areas for improvement, and adjust strategies accordingly.
- **Know When to Engage and When to Withdraw:** Sun Tzu advises knowing when to engage in battle and when to withdraw to avoid unnecessary losses. In training, this means knowing when to push participants to their limits and when to allow for rest and recovery to prevent burnout or injury.

- **Maintain Morale:** Morale plays a significant role in warfare and training alike. Sun Tzu stresses the importance of maintaining high morale among troops. In training, positive reinforcement, encouragement, and camaraderie can help boost morale and motivation.

By incorporating these principles into training programs, leaders can cultivate effective and resilient teams capable of overcoming challenges and achieving success.

Chapter-5
Communication Principle

Sun Tzu said,

"If words of command are not clear and distinct, if orders are not thoroughly understood, the general is to blame. But if his orders ARE clear, and the soldiers nevertheless disobey, then it is the fault of their officers."

In his first introductory lesson, the story of the concubines, Sun Tzu educated us on the necessities of clarity of communication, the discipline of teams as well as appropriate good execution of orders, otherwise serious consequences can occur. He said, "If words of command are not clear and distinct, if orders are not thoroughly understood, then the general is to blame."

The Lesson of the Concubines

The following story is considered not part of the thirteen chapters.

Sun Tzu earned him an audience with the King of Wu, who said, "I have thoroughly read your thirteen chapters. May I submit your theory of managing soldiers to a small test?"

Sun Tzu replied, "Sir, you may."

The King of Wu asked, "Can the test be applied to women?"

Sun Tzu replied that it could, so arrangements were made to bring 180 beautiful women from the palace. Sun Tzu divided them into

two companies, with one of the King's favorite concubines at the head of each. He then made all of them take spears in their hands and spoke to them: "I presume you know the difference between front and back, right hand, and left hand?"

The women replied, "Yes."

Sun Tzu continued, "When to the sound of drums, I order 'eyes front,' look straight ahead. When I order 'left turn,' face toward your left hand. When I order 'right turn,' face toward your right hand. When I order 'about turn,' face around to the back." After the words of command had been explained, the women agreed they understood. He gave them spears so he could begin the drill. To the sound of drums, Sun Tzu ordered, "right turn." In response, the women burst out in laughter.

With great patience, Sun Tzu said, "If the instructions and words of command are not clear and distinct, if orders are not thoroughly understood, then the general is to blame." He then repeated the "left turn," and again the women burst into laughter.

Then Sun Tzu said, "If the instructions and words of command are not clear and distinct, if orders are not thoroughly understood, the general is to blame. But if commands are clear and the soldiers disobey, then it is the fault of the officers." He immediately ordered the women who were at the head of the two companies to be beheaded.

Of course, the King was watching from a raised pavilion. When he saw that his two favorite concubines were about to be executed, he was alarmed and swiftly sent down a message: “We are now quite satisfied as to the general’s ability to manage troops. Without these concubines, my food and drink will not taste good. It is the King’s wish that they not be beheaded.”

Sun Tzu replied, “Having received the sovereign’s commission to take charge and direct these troops, there are certain orders I cannot accept.” He immediately had the two concubines beheaded as an example and appointed the two next in line as the new leaders.

Now the drums were sounded again ,and the drill began. The women performed all the maneuvers exactly as commanded, turning to the right or left, marching ahead, turning around, kneeling, or rising. They drilled perfectly in precision and did not utter a single sound.

Sun Tzu sent a messenger to the King of Wu, saying, “Your Majesty, the soldiers are now correctly drilled and perfectly disciplined. They are ready for your inspection. Put them to any use you desire. As sovereign, you may choose to require them to go through fire and water and they will not disobey.”

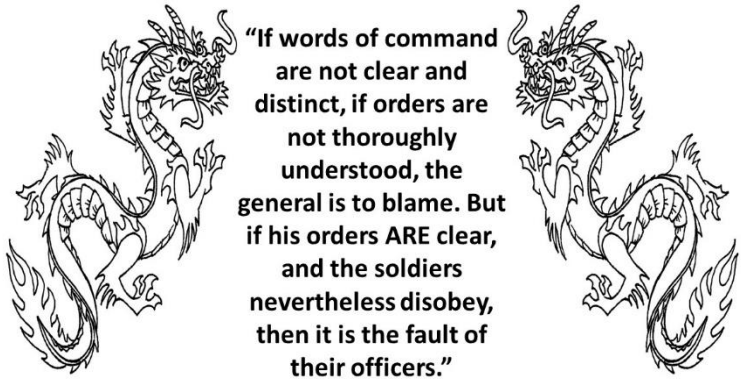
The King responded, “Our commander should cease the drill and return to his camp. We do not wish to come down and inspect the troops.”

With great calm, Sun Tzu said, “This king is only fond of words and cannot carry them into deeds.”

Commentary following the story indicates that the King relented, recognized Sun Tzu’s ability, and appointed him a general ,and Sun Tzu won many battles. In contrast, some historians believe Sun Tzu simply served as a civilian strategist, and others deny his existence, claiming he was actually someone else.

The *moral* of the story could be a lesson on training, discipline, command structure, role-play, or perhaps job interviews. The thoughtful reader may use his imagination to determine applicable lessons.

Sun Tzu, insisted on clear communication by the leader, otherwise leader would be responsible for all the consequences.



It is generally recognized that effective communication is a requisite of effective management. Communication is an important part of the HR job that can’t be taken for granted, and regardless of

the size of your organization, smart HR practitioners who know that clear communication is the essence of business,can create an opportunity for employees to understand and take action of the message they are sending.

Thus, communication must be simple and far from ambiguity or usage of jargon language.

Chapter-6
Leadership Principle

Organizations depend upon leaders and their leadership capabilities to guide them during trying times.

Sun Tzu said,

"***Next is the Commander. He must be smart, trustworthy, caring, brave, and strict***."

Accordingly, the commander/leader must have those five traits: smart, trustworthy, caring, brave, and strict. These qualities describe a person's character.

HR executives must ensure that organizational leaders and themselves are ''Smart'' in order to be able to understand where the environment provides the best opportunities An intelligent executive must be able to rightly understand the competitor's leader and use the appropriate technique to gain an advantage.

Generally speaking, the challenge faced by many of today's executives is that they have backgrounds as good technical practitioners who were promoted to their current management roles. They know their industry well but cannot distinguish between management and leadership beyond a mere intellectual understanding.

To be respected as executives in today's business climate, we must be relevant and manage the inevitable business climate changes and the follow-on strategy changes with good HR science.



Executives ''Trustworthiness'' must inspire their staff's devotion, and subsequently, the staff must never fear danger or dishonesty. They must represent employees with keen concern to the top management, discuss their issues and fight for them, and bring mutual agreement to the discussion table. They can have true influence and leverage over an organization, bringing the functional expertise to bear without artificial limitation, where appropriate, for the greater good of the organization.

Also, they ought to take ''Care'' of staff members and also treat them as their beloved children. In this way, HR may intervene in coaching and counseling sessions to solve or try to solve issues behind job-related matters and help organizations and employees balance the demands of work along with the need for a personal life.

Sun Tzu suggests that the leader should be brave for obvious reasons. The modern equivalent could be “openness to experience.” This trait is key to using feedback from subordinates to improve one’s performance by establishing internal listening as a priority and encouraging two-way interaction. We must be willing to do the unpleasant parts of the job as well as the fun parts and honor our agreements conscientiously. People must be able to depend on us.

If we are not reliable, no one will support us for long. If our decisions are well thought out and we act honestly, our men will trust us. If we are trusted, people will speak their minds freely and openly, which means business problems can be solved more quickly and effectively. This is being strict.

Chapter-7
Planning Principle

Benjamin Franklin, the father of time management, said, “Failing to plan is planning to fail.”

Sun Tzu was very clear about the need for careful planning, he said,

“***With careful and detailed planning, one can win; with careless and less detailed planning, one cannot win. How much more certain is defeat if one does not plan at all? From the way planning is done beforehand, we can predict victory or defeat.***”

“Planning” is an objective analysis of the competitive situation. He emphasized the important aspect of ‘‘laying plans’’ ,and how careful planning can significantly increase the chance of victory and deviation from these plans will ensure failure.



In HRM, recruitment and training should be planned based on internal and external environmental factors. HR practitioners should know the strengths and weaknesses of every employee and use them to their advantage against the competition. Human Resources planning, in the broadest sense, includes both strategic and operational human resources as a continuous process rather than an activity limited to a fixed segment of the business planning process.

Sun Tzu believed it was not possible to win a war without the support of the soldiers and population. If HR is to be successful, employees should be highly motivated and loyal to the organization. Individuals who have different objectives for the organization should be replaced, as they will be less likely to make personal sacrifices when required.

Sun Tzu asserted, “If you know the enemy and know yourself, you need not fear the result of a hundred battles. If you know yourself but not the enemy, for every victory gained you will also suffer a defeat. If you know neither the enemy nor yourself, you will succumb in every battle.”

Organizations are becoming more dependent upon people because they are increasingly involved in more complex technologies and are attempting to function in more complex economic, political, and socio-cultural environments.

The more different technical skills are involved in the design, manufacture, marketing, and sales of a product, the more

vulnerable the organization will be to critical shortages of the right kinds of human resources.

HR Planning plays an eminent role in the organization to achieve its goals. Surprisingly, this aspect of HR is one of the most neglected in the field. The importance of HR planning has generally been overlooked by organizations. Its proactive approach allows it to be more strategic in its decisions rather than face obstacles when unprepared.

It can enhance the success of an organization through anticipation of labor shortages or surpluses and thus make decisions about the overall qualitative and quantitative balance of employees.

HR Practitioners who prepare the HR Planning program would assist the organization in managing its staff strategically. They must perform environmental scanning in order to effectively be a part of the strategic planning process by monitoring the major external forces influencing the organization ,such as economic factors, competitive trends, technological changes, political issues, social issues, and demographic trends.

Unfortunately, many organizations think HR Plans are all about payroll budget, benefits ,and some minor training expenses.

Townsville Business Coach says, “If you don’t have a plan: you will become part of someone else’s plan. And you may not like it…”

Chapter-8
Managing Change Principle

The success of an organization depends on four conditions: common purpose, responsiveness to the environment, able leadership, and effective flow of information.

"The organization in which leaders and employees are united in purpose will be successful."

All organizations are subject to changes of various degrees of complexity and significance. Changes occur in the organization's environment through technological innovations, legislative amendments, new competitive challenges, shifting demographics, and globalization. The management of change is the process by which the organization adapts to these changing conditions. It represents a significant challenge to the Human Resources practitioner who needs to assess the organization's readiness to adapt and champion the process.

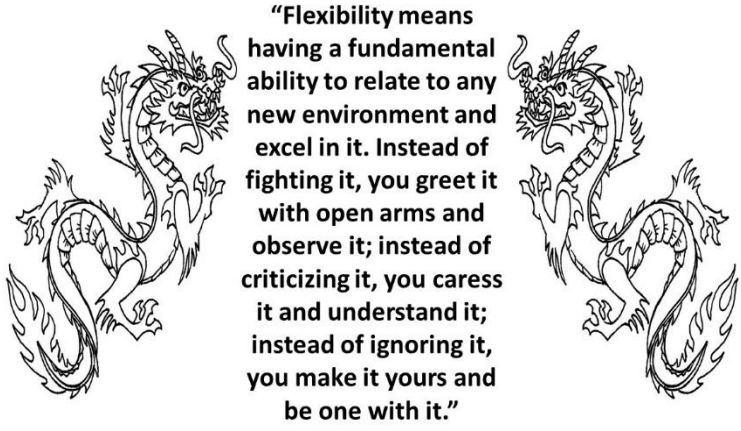
The leader's greatest responsibility is to align the organization with a common purpose. That means that the thoughts and deeds of every member of the organization are aligned with the goals the leader has established. In this way, expert leaders can have very subtle control over the whole organization, just as if they were directing a person by holding his hand.

What can we do to achieve this kind of alignment? It is mainly the product of the leader's example. Exemplary conduct springs from a noble character and corresponding behavior. As a result, leaders are able to establish and maintain harmony inside the organization. Harmony in the organization and the leader's exemplary character are two sides of the same coin.

When the authority of leaders is highly respected, it is easier to form a harmonious relationship between them and their employees. The authority of leaders does not stem from their position but from their noble character and their example.

Their duty is to ensure that harmony exists in the organization. They do this by preventing internal conflicts, enforcing order and discipline, and being a role model to follow. Unless they do this, leaders cannot earn respect from members of their organization.

In China, dynasties that were not able to keep the peace (harmony) and experienced frequent upheavals were said to have lost "heaven's favor." Contrary to the Western system where the rulers' legitimacy comes from the democratic tradition, in China, it was believed that rulers received their power from heaven. When the society was in chaos, it meant that heaven had withdrawn its mandate.



This idea of maintaining social stability is still very important in today's China. Generally speaking, the Chinese seek harmony and try to eliminate conflicts in their organizations. If there is no way to avoid conflicts, then they pretend they don't exist. Conflicts are rarely dealt with publicly; they appear to be concealed when they occur.

We can approach the concept of harmony in two different ways.

On the one hand, it means uniformity of ideas and behavior; on the other, it means the blending of different ideas and opinions.

The concept of fertile harmony corresponds to the latter. It is impossible to create music with one tone even if it is repeated a thousand times. In order to produce music, we need to mix the sounds of different instruments, just as to create a succulent dish, we need to combine different ingredients.

The harmony we are talking about here belongs to the second type. Leaders must be able to bring together different people with

different backgrounds and opinions and unite them towards the achievement of a common purpose, a necessary condition for success.

Good leaders should respect diversity and be able to co-ordinate people with different ideas and concepts, encouraging them to work towards a common purpose, thus achieving unity in variety and diversity.

"***Just as the water flows according to the terrain, so an organization will vary its methods of succeeding according to the competition.***"

Paying attention to the organization and the creation of a common purpose is what we call the internal focus. However, leaders also need to pay attention to the outside environment, the external focus.

The success or failure of a company is largely due to the quality of its leaders' decisions; therefore, these must be taken based on a sound understanding of the external environment.

There are no recipes for success, especially in a dynamic environment in which conditions constantly change. What used to work in the past may not necessarily work now.

Therefore, every situation may require a new approach to reach a decision. Leaders must possess the ability to innovate continuously and be able to make correct decisions in new situations. This is the quality of good judgment.

Every company has its competitive advantages and a unique strategic position ,but utilizing these can be a difficult task. Competitive advantages include intangible assets such as trust in the leader, employees' commitment to the organization, the leader's awareness of opportunities available in the macro-environment, and flexibility when facing change. The strategic position involves tangible elements such as economic strength and the quality of assets.

Able leaders utilize their company's competitive advantages and strategic position in accordance with the conditions in the environment. At the same time, competitive advantages and strategic position do not last forever. On the contrary, their relevance will depend on the environmental conditions.

Therefore, we should actively adjust the organization to new situations as they appear. Leaders should actively create flexible and responsive organizations,so that they can make better use of the company's competitive advantages.

"***The leader is at the core of the company. With an able leader, a company has all the possibilities to succeed. Without an able leader, a company will be in chaos.***"

Leadership originates from a noble character. There are five virtues a leader should cultivate to overcome five weaknesses.

The five weaknesses to overcome are: recklessness, insecurity, volatility, sensitivity to criticism, and leniency. All these

weaknesses will affect a leader's decision-making process and therefore have an impact on the company's success.

As we noted, past success does not guarantee future success. Recklessness implies a decision made with incomplete consideration. Insecurity will result in indecision ,and this will make one afraid of change. Volatility will hurt one's relationship with subordinates. When a leader is unable to control himself, how can he win the respect of others? Leaders who cannot control their temper expose to others nothing but their incompetence.

Similarly, over-sensitiveness to criticism is another barrier to self-improvement. If we are not willing to listen to others' feedback, we are missing opportunities for self-improvement and learning. Some employees may even hide problems from their superiors for fear of irritating them.

The last weakness, leniency, is about sentimentalism. It causes a leader's undue involvement with the personal problems of employees. An erroneous message is passed to people when leaders mix their personal feelings with the understanding of problems and tolerate employees' misbehavior. Then, some people will be likely to take advantage of the leader's weakness, while others will feel unjustly treated.

Leniency will damage the effectiveness of the company as the employees become like spoiled children. Leaders should avoid excessive familiarity and involvement in employees' personal

matters. They should keep an appropriate distance from their employees and be mature, calm,and fair.

Besides the five weaknesses to be avoided, the five qualities to be cultivated are: integrity, courage, kindness, discipline, and wisdom.

Integrity is about matching words and actions to "walk the talk". Only persons of integrity can win others' trust since they deliver their promises. Trust is the foundation of the leader's authority. Leaders should possess courage, so they can make decisions at critical moments. These decisions should be resolute and sound at the same time. Leaders win their battles before fighting them.

As for kindness, leaders should consider the well-being of every member of the organization and respect the value of every person. In addition to kindness, discipline is also essential. One has to first discipline oneself before managing others. Leaders should set up an example by abiding by the norms of the organization; only then is possible to ask others to follow them.

Able leaders should not only win gratitude through their care towards others but also unite them through disciplinary measures. The combination of kindness and discipline is what guarantees employees' loyalty to their leaders. This is also developed by the leader's exemplary conduct.

Finally, and perhaps most importantly, leaders must have wisdom. Wise leaders consider problems systematically and can plan their actions based on a sound understanding of the business environment after careful analysis of the strengths and weaknesses

of the company. They must be flexible and not follow conventional rules; instead, they should take action when necessary. They do not oppose change but foster it to promote the progress and development of their company.

Wisdom in this sense also means the ability to be aware of the conditions of a particular situation and be able to foresee the result of one's action. The external environment is the outcome of a dynamic process with various independent elements interacting with each other. Therefore, a decision made to tackle a particular problem faced by a company will affect other parts of the organization. From this, we can see that true wisdom is a combination of good judgment and opportunity.

Leaders' decisions are of critical importance to the success or failure of an organization. Cultivating these five qualities as the source of leadership is not something external to an individual but comes from within. Leadership originates from within a person rather than from the possession of special skills. Able leaders are like a treasure to their companies.

"***A well-designed organization makes managing many employees the same as managing a few***."

A good organization should have a proper control system, clear communication channels, sound allocation of resources ,and talented middle practitioners. The last point is fundamental because the determinant factor of success is not so much the competitive advantages of the company but the people constituting the

organization who can leverage those competitive advantages. Therefore, one should not resist or oppose providing the necessary resources that can attract talented people.

A critical point in the management of people is a fair system of rewards and punishments. When many rewards are given, it only indicates that a company has many problems. Similarly, if too many punishments are enforced, it indicates that the company lacks a common purpose. Justice and fairness are also very important when making decisions on internal transfers and promotions. Lastly, proper training plays a fundamental role in the proper use of human capital.

There are two characteristics of the fluid flow of information in an organization.

First, it must be focused on the obtaining and transmission of information. Second, it must be able to adapt to the changing conditions of the environment. Only then can an organization survive a highly competitive and constantly changing environment. Past decisions are not a good guide for the future.

The ability to continuously reinvent itself is a company's greatest advantage. The secret of success lies in the achievement of organization united around a common purpose with a leader who respects the individual, treasures diversity, tries to create a harmonious atmosphere, and constantly monitors the external environment, ceaselessly obtaining information and taking effective action to adapt itself to changing conditions.

Furthermore, leaders have a fundamental role in this model. They must possess a noble character, being a role model for the rest of the members of the organization.

The leader plays a crucial role in this model. There is a saying in China: if a soldier is incompetent, it is the problem of one, but if the general is incompetent, then it becomes the problem of the whole army. Leaders should be an example to the whole organization. Their authority comes from their noble character.

The old question is whether leaders are born or made. In this model, leadership can be developed through personal efforts.

How can we become leaders?

The answer comes from the five qualities to foster: integrity, courage, kindness, self-discipline, and wisdom. A manager who cultivates these five virtues will gradually become a model in the eyes of employees.

In contrast to the Western view of leadership, where leaders are at the top of the organization with the organization serving them, in this model, leaders occupy the center of the organization and serve the organization. They are like the center of a wheel. All the spokes meet at the hub. If the hub is not strong enough the wheel will inevitably collapse.

Let's conclude this exploration of Sun Tzu's ideas with one of his well-known quotes:

"***Know your competitors, know yourself and success will never be at risk. Know the ground, know the natural conditions, and success can be total.***"

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Sun Tzu's principles from *The Art of War* can be applied to various fields, including human resources management (HRM). Here's how Sun Tzu's ideas relate to managing change in HRM:

Know Your Employees and Environment: Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of understanding your environment and adversaries. In HRM, this translates to understanding your employees' strengths, weaknesses, motivations, and the organizational culture. This knowledge is crucial for implementing change effectively, as it helps HR practitioners anticipate resistance and tailor their strategies accordingly.

Adaptability: Sun Tzu stresses the need for flexibility and adaptability in warfare. Similarly, in HRM, adaptability is essential when implementing change initiatives. HR practitioners should be prepared to adjust their strategies based on feedback, emerging challenges, and changing circumstances within the organization.

Leadership and Communication: Sun Tzu emphasizes the role of leadership and effective communication in achieving victory. In HRM, effective leadership is critical for driving change and gaining employee buy-in. HR practitioners need to communicate the rationale behind the proposed changes clearly, address concerns, and provide support throughout the transition process.

Change Management Tactics: Sun Tzu's principles, such as the importance of surprise and deception, can be applied to change management tactics in HRM. HR practitioners may strategically introduce changes to minimize resistance and maximize acceptance among employees. This could involve involving key stakeholders early in the process, managing rumors and misinformation, and gradually implementing changes to allow for adaptation.

Risk Management: Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of assessing risks and minimizing vulnerabilities.

In HRM, effective change management involves identifying potential risks and developing mitigation strategies. HR practitioners should anticipate potential obstacles to change, such as employee resistance, lack of resources, or competing priorities, and proactively address them to ensure the success of the change initiative.

Overall, Sun Tzu's principles provide valuable insights into managing change effectively in HRM by emphasizing the importance of understanding the environment, adaptability, leadership, communication, change management tactics, and risk management.

By applying these principles, HR practitioners can navigate the complexities of organizational change and achieve their objectives while minimizing disruptions and maximizing employee engagement and productivity.

Chapter-9
Performance Appraisal Principle

In the past several years, some people have argued passionately against performance appraisals. So, the question is:

To Appraise or Not to Appraise?

Edwards Deming said, “Performance appraisal, in its present form, rewards people for manipulating the system rather than improving it.”

Performance appraisal failures can occur for various reasons, and they can have significant repercussions for both the employee and the organization. The common causes and potential consequences of performance appraisal failures:

Lack of Clear Criteria: If the criteria for evaluating performance are vague or inconsistent, employees may not understand what is expected of them, leading to misunderstandings and unfair evaluations.

Bias: Appraisers may harbor unconscious biases that influence their assessments, resulting in unfair treatment and inaccurate evaluations. This can include biases related to gender, race, age, or personal relationships.

Inadequate Training: Managers and appraisers may not receive sufficient training on how to conduct performance appraisals effectively, leading to errors in judgment and communication.

Poor Communication: If feedback is not provided in a timely and constructive manner, employees may feel demotivated and disengaged. Lack of communication can also lead to misunderstandings about performance expectations.

Failure to Align with Organizational Goals: Performance appraisals should be linked to organizational goals and objectives. If there is a disconnect between individual performance and the broader goals of the organization, appraisals may fail to provide meaningful insights.

Overemphasis on Ratings: Some organizations focus too much on assigning numerical ratings or rankings to employees, leading to a competitive rather than developmental culture. This can foster resentment and hinder collaboration.

Lack of Follow-Up: Performance appraisals should not be viewed as a one-time event but as part of an ongoing process of performance management. Failure to follow up on appraisal feedback and goals can undermine the effectiveness of the process.

Consequences of performance appraisal failures may include:

- Decreased morale and motivation among employees.
- Increased turnover and talent loss.

- Legal implications if appraisals are perceived as discriminatory or unfair.
- Reduced productivity and performance due to unclear expectations and lack of feedback.
- Negative impact on organizational culture and employee engagement.

To address performance appraisal failures, organizations should prioritize transparency, fairness, and ongoing communication in their performance management processes. This may involve providing training to managers, revising appraisal criteria, soliciting feedback from employees, and ensuring that performance appraisals are integrated into broader talent management strategies.

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Pertinent questions in the aforesaid context are: Can performance parameters be objectively laid down or specifically delineated and measured? Can performance be limited to the strict construct of job design? To what extent do employees redefine their roles as per subjective role preferences, imparting their own unique understanding to it in the sense of emphasizing certain aspects and deemphasizing certain others? To what extent are jobs means or ends for purposive behavior in an organizational situation?

Does role constitute ‘‘fact’’ to the exclusion of value? How can value be articulated and assessed for better study of organizational behavior? To what extent do employees impart value to fact? It is an accepted fact of organizational life that employees do impart

personal values to job performance as per their perception of issues.

Also, is the value imparted by an employee to an organization measurable? Fact and value are inextricable in real-life situations (purposive behavior).

In the same vein, can ‘‘behavior’’ be cataloged along specifically crafted indices? Is it at all possible to have a ‘‘scientific’’ performance appraisal?

Aforesaid questions are some of the challenges for human resources management today. Ideally, performance should be appraised by indices. All aspects of a job should be articulated clearly, such as interpersonal relations, punctuality, quality of work, etc., and should be used to allot marks or grades with a view to measuring them.

A one-shot statement may not make for objective performance appraisal though, disquietingly, forms organizational practice at lower levels in many organizations.

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Sun Tzu’s principles within this context could be interpreted as follows:

Know Your People: Sun Tzu emphasized the importance of knowing your soldiers, their strengths, weaknesses, and motivations. Similarly, in performance appraisal, understanding

each employee's capabilities, areas for improvement, and career aspirations is essential for fair and effective evaluations.

Set Clear Objectives: Sun Tzu stressed the need for clear objectives in any endeavor. In performance appraisal, employees should be evaluated based on how well they have met specific, measurable objectives and goals set for them.

Reward and Punishment: Sun Tzu discussed the judicious use of rewards and punishment to motivate troops. Similarly, performance appraisal involves recognizing and rewarding employees for exceptional performance while providing constructive feedback or corrective actions for underperformance.

Adaptability: Sun Tzu emphasized the importance of adapting strategies to changing circumstances. Similarly, performance appraisal systems should be flexible enough to accommodate changes in job roles, responsibilities, and organizational priorities.

Continuous Improvement: Sun Tzu stressed the importance of continuous learning and improvement. In performance appraisal, the focus should not only be on past performance but also on identifying opportunities for development and growth for the future.

Fairness and Impartiality: Sun Tzu emphasized the importance of fairness and impartiality in leadership. Similarly, a performance appraisal should be conducted objectively, without bias or

favoritism, to maintain employee morale and trust in the evaluation process.

While Sun Tzu's writings may not directly address performance appraisal, his timeless principles of leadership and strategy can certainly be applied to enhance the effectiveness and fairness of the evaluation process in organizations.

Chapter-10
Strategies Principle

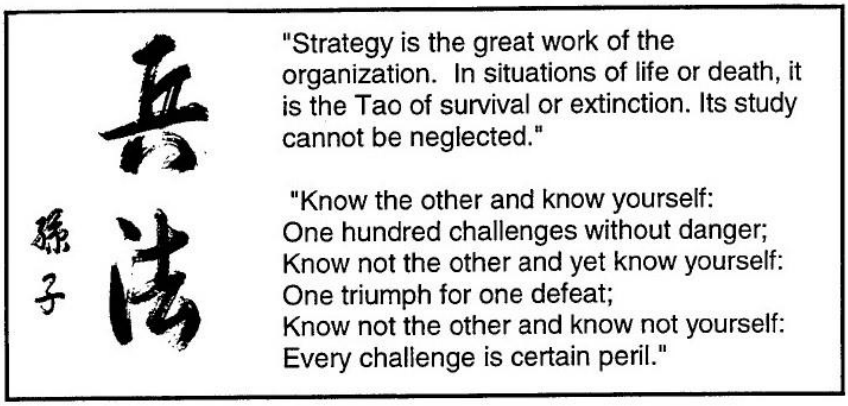
To meet the challenges of the future, you must have a strategy to ensure success. Strategic objectives are often one of the most challenging components of a strategic plan because they create the bridge between your big, bold vision and the annual goals needed to achieve it.

HR practitioners have a great deal to learn from military strategists and probably the most important lesson is that the ultimate effectiveness of any individual ‘‘soldier’’ is determined primarily by the strategy they are working to rather than their capabilities.

Strategic objectives establish the boundaries for what your department’s effort must focus on. They create the top layer of your strategic plan’s framework, articulating what you’ll focus on to achieve your vision of success.

In *The Art of War,* Sun Tzu said,

“Strategy without tactics is the slowest route to victory. Tactics without strategy is the noise before defeat.”



Sun Tzu's ancient text, *The Art of War*, primarily focuses on military strategy, but its principles can be applied to various areas, including human resources management.

HR business strategy , as with any type of strategy, is not about individual battles but the waging of a complete war against the competition. It is the common thread that ties each individual's actions into a common cause.

Effective strategies should, by definition, produce effective MOs (modus operandi). The ethos, principles, values , and objectives of the organization should all be encapsulated within an HR business strategy.

Human Resources as a strategist refers to the evolving role of HR professionals within organizations, where they actively contribute to the formulation and execution of business strategies. Traditionally seen as primarily administrative or compliance-focused, HR has increasingly become recognized as a strategic

partner in driving organizational success. Here's how HR can function as a strategist:

Aligning HR with Business Objectives: HR professionals work closely with senior management to understand the organization's goals and objectives. By aligning HR practices with these business objectives, HR can ensure that the workforce is equipped with the right skills, competencies, and mindset to support the company's strategic direction.

Talent Management and Development: HR strategists focus on identifying and developing talent within the organization. This involves not only recruitment and hiring but also employee training, development, and succession planning. By ensuring that the right people are in the right roles, HR contributes directly to achieving business goals.

Organizational Design and Change Management: HR plays a crucial role in organizational design, ensuring that structures, processes, and systems support the company's strategic objectives. Additionally, HR professionals facilitate change management initiatives, helping employees adapt to new strategies, technologies, or organizational structures.

Data-Driven Decision Making: HR strategists leverage data analytics to inform decision-making processes. By analyzing workforce data, HR can identify trends, anticipate future talent needs, and assess the effectiveness of HR programs and initiatives.

This data-driven approach enables HR to make strategic recommendations that drive business performance.

Employee Engagement and Culture: HR plays a key role in fostering employee engagement and building a positive organizational culture. Engaged employees are more likely to be productive, innovative, and committed to the company's success. HR strategists focus on creating an environment where employees feel valued, empowered, and motivated to contribute their best.

Managing Human Capital Risks: HR strategists are responsible for mitigating human capital risks that could impact the organization's ability to achieve its strategic objectives. This includes compliance with labor laws and regulations, managing diversity and inclusion initiatives, and addressing issues such as employee turnover or talent shortages.

Collaboration with Other Departments: HR professionals collaborate with other departments such as finance, operations, marketing, and sales to ensure that HR strategies are integrated with overall business strategies. This cross-functional collaboration ensures alignment and coherence across different areas of the organization.

By embracing the role of strategist, HR professionals can make significant contributions to organizational success by ensuring that the workforce is effectively leveraged to achieve strategic objectives.

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Applying Sun Tzu's strategies to Human Resources Management (HRM) can offer insightful approaches to managing people and organizations effectively. Sun Tzu's *The Art of War* emphasizes the importance of strategy, leadership, and understanding the competitive landscape.

Know Your Employees and Yourself: Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of self-awareness and understanding the enemy. In HRM, this translates to understanding your employees' strengths, weaknesses, motivations, and career aspirations, as well as understanding your organization's culture, goals, and challenges.

Strategic Workforce Planning: Sun Tzu stresses the importance of planning and preparation. HRM should involve strategic workforce planning, anticipating future skill needs, talent gaps, and market trends to ensure the organization has the right people in the right roles at the right time.

Effective Recruitment and Selection: Sun Tzu advises on the importance of selecting the right people for the right roles. HRM should focus on recruiting top talent that aligns with the organization's values, culture, and strategic objectives.

Training and Development: Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of training and preparation for success in battle. Similarly, HRM should invest in employee training and development programs to enhance skills, capabilities, and readiness for current and future challenges.

Motivation and Morale: Sun Tzu stresses the significance of morale in warfare. In HRM, it's essential to motivate employees, boost morale, and create a positive work environment to foster engagement, productivity, and loyalty.

Effective Leadership: Sun Tzu highlights the role of leadership in guiding and inspiring troops to victory. HRM should focus on developing effective leaders who can inspire, coach, and empower employees to achieve their full potential.

Adaptability and Flexibility: Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of adaptability and flexibility in responding to changing circumstances. HRM should be agile and adaptable to changes in the business environment, industry trends, and technological advancements.

Conflict Resolution: Sun Tzu offers strategies for resolving conflicts and minimizing confrontation. HRM should employ effective conflict resolution techniques to address disputes, grievances, and interpersonal conflicts in the workplace.

Information and Intelligence: Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of intelligence gathering and information advantage. HRM should gather data, feedback, and insights to make informed decisions about workforce planning, performance management, and organizational development.

Strategic Alliances and Partnerships: Sun Tzu discusses the value of alliances and partnerships in achieving strategic

objectives. HRM should cultivate partnerships with external stakeholders, such as educational institutions, industry associations, and recruitment agencies, to enhance talent acquisition, employer branding, and innovation.

By applying Sun Tzu's timeless principles to HRM, organizations can enhance their competitive advantage, optimize their human capital, and achieve long-term success in today's dynamic business landscape. Overall, while *The Art of War* may be a military treatise, its principles can be effectively adapted and applied by HR professionals to enhance organizational performance, build a strong workforce, and achieve strategic objectives.


Strategy without tactics is the slowest route to victory. Tactics without strategy is the noise before defeat.
Sun Tzu

Chapter-11
For Practitioners

Here are six guidelines on how to manage people as Sun Tzu does :

- **Scale Your Team to a Manageable Size:** A high-functioning team should limit its number of people in order to agilely scale. Depending on the industry and company culture, I recommend that my clients have no more than twenty people on their team.
- **Assess People's State of Being:** Sun Tzu explains people's motivations and moods, and how to maneuver depending on these motivations in various situations. I once had a client who, despite his organization's funds drying out, didn't want to try any proposed solutions. Even though he said he was motivated to "save the organization," he didn't make any effort to do so. Why? Because he hated his job. A few resumes later, he found a new job and the organization found new, more motivated leadership.
- **Self-assess First:** In Chapter 8, Sun Tzu lists people management as one of the five advantages of assessing your areas of improvement. He recommends self-assessment to understand more about yourself and, eventually, your enemy. Along the same lines, we offer 360 Personal Brand Assessments that our clients send out to 50 people anonymously. As we review their self-assessment and

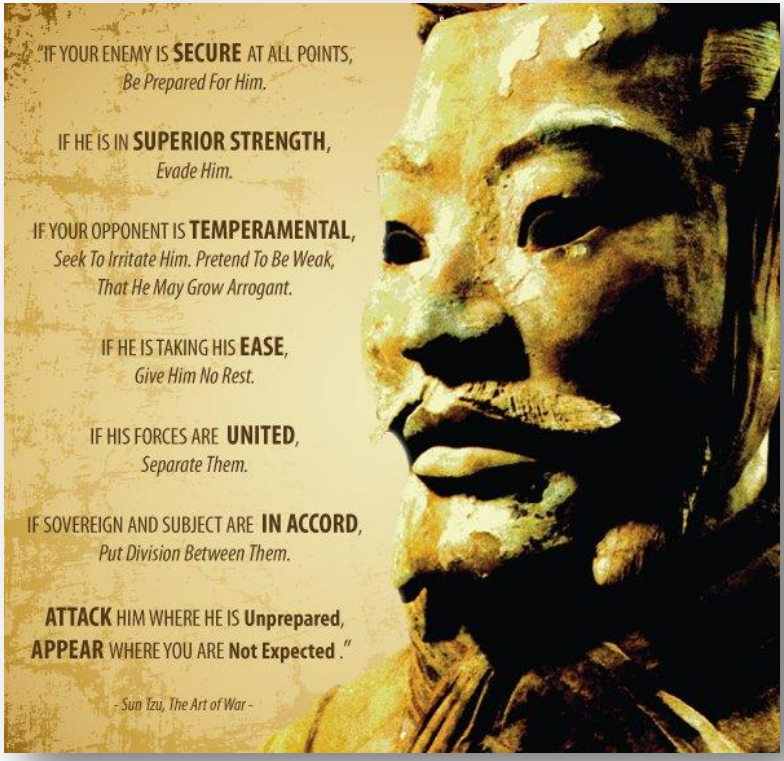
feedback from others, we often find a correlation between how they assessed themselves and how others perceived them. It's an eye-opening moment for our clients on how they can improve!

- **Examine Other People for Insights into Conflict Preparation:** Sun Tzu looks to his team to understand how to prepare for conflict, and you should too. For successful conflict resolution, we usually rehearse and role-play various outcomes with our clients. It helps them understand the nature of conflict and how to effectively create win-win solutions.
- **Don't Rush or Micromanage:** Sun Tzu explains the faults of leaders "who rush, tarry, fall, crumble, riot and are beaten." A former client embodied these traits, as he lacked delegation skills. His team watched videos all day but were then given last-minute deadlines. This meant team members often had to stay late and sometimes work overnight. Needless to say, turnover was high.
- **Recognize "Double Agents" in Your Organization:** Sun Tzu discusses the five categories of spies. He outlines how to get information from five different types of people, including double agents. We understand the importance of recognizing double agents within your organization, so we offer a 13-week leadership program based on Sun Tzu's advice that includes dealing with spies.

In a nutshell:

1. **Detailed Planning & Assessment:** Don't rush into action before thoroughly assessing the situation.
2. **Waging War:** You need a sound tactical plan to implement your broad strategic plan.
3. **Strategic Attacks:** Strategy = enacting the war on paper. Seek to win with minimal confrontation.
4. **Tactical Dispositions:** Strategy comes before tactics, but your strategy must also consider tactical elements.
5. **Use of Forces:** Your leaders and command system decide how resources are controlled and deployed in battle.
6. **Strength vs Weakness:** To win, pool your strengths against your enemy's weaknesses.
7. **Maneuvering:** Think of ways to put your enemy at a disadvantage, then refine your approach as you take action.
8. **Tactical Variation:** As you implement your strategy, adjust your tactics based on real-time feedback.
9. **Moving & Deploying Troops:** Own a strong, secure position and use it as a strategic base for your attacks.
10. **Terrain:** Know your terrain (internal/external areas of business operations) to make winning decisions.
11. **The 9 Battlegrounds:** Match your strategy with the battleground, always seeking to have the advantage.
12. **Attack with Fire:** Fire is a powerful offensive weapon that can bring great damage to the enemy.

13. **Intelligence & Espionage:** Gather, organize, integrate, and disseminate information effectively for better decisions.



Chapter-12
Conclusion

Leveraging Sun Tzu's *The Art of War* in human resources applications can offer valuable insights into strategic management, conflict resolution, leadership, and organizational behavior. Here's how some of the principles from *The Art of War* can be applied in HR:

Know Your Employees and Competitors: Understanding the strengths, weaknesses, skills, and motivations of your employees is crucial for effective management. Similarly, being aware of your competitors' strengths and weaknesses can help in strategic planning.

Adaptability: Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of flexibility and adaptability in warfare. In HR, this translates to being agile and responsive to changes in the business environment, industry trends, and workforce dynamics.

Leadership: *The Art of War* highlights the significance of strong leadership. HR professionals can use this principle to develop effective leadership programs, identify and nurture leadership talent within the organization, and create a culture of leadership at all levels.

Strategy and Planning: Sun Tzu stresses the importance of strategic planning and foresight. HR professionals can apply this

by developing long-term workforce plans, succession planning, talent acquisition strategies, and performance management systems aligned with the organization's goals.

Talent Management: Just as generals strategically deploy their troops, HR practitioners strategically deploy talent within the organization. This involves matching the right people to the right roles, developing talent pipelines, and creating opportunities for employee growth and development.

Conflict Resolution: *The Art of War* offers strategies for resolving conflicts through negotiation, diplomacy, and understanding the motivations of different parties. HR professionals can apply these principles to manage conflicts in the workplace effectively, fostering a culture of collaboration and teamwork.

Risk Management: Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of risk assessment and mitigation. HR can use this principle to identify potential risks related to workforce management, such as talent shortages, employee turnover, and compliance issues, and develop strategies to address them proactively.

Information Management: Sun Tzu emphasizes the value of accurate and timely information in decision-making. HR professionals can use this principle to leverage data analytics and HR technology to gather insights into workforce trends, performance metrics, and employee engagement levels.

The Art of War remains a timeless masterpiece that provides valuable lessons on strategy, leadership, and conflict resolution. Sun Tzu's teachings extend beyond warfare, resonating in modern-day contexts such as business, politics, and personal growth.

By emphasizing the importance of thorough preparation, understanding the enemy, and adapting strategies to changing circumstances, Sun Tzu's principles offer timeless guidance for achieving success. This ancient Chinese military treatise continues to inspire and enlighten individuals seeking to master the art of strategy in both their professional and personal lives.

By applying the principles of *The Art of War* in HR, organizations can enhance their strategic management capabilities, improve employee engagement and productivity, and achieve their business objectives more effectively.

“Sun Tzu’s masterpiece is not only a text on strategy and maneuvers, but also one of the first reflections on human psychology in warfare.”

Chapter-13
Take away Principles

The Principle of Advancement

Strategy is the science of advancing positions. All advances must start at your current position. Your current position has everything in it that you need to advance. The worst position is, by definition, the easiest to advance.

Each position is a stepping-stone to future positions. Positions can change through luck alone, but they can only be consistently advanced by skill.

The Principle of Instinct

People make decisions based solely on existing emotions and habits until they are trained to provide a new set of responses. The only inborn instinctual responses are flight or fight. All more advanced responses must be learned through trial and error or training.

Since most people are untrained, you can predict their behavior by understanding the most basic emotions and common habits.

The Principle of Perspective

Each individual has a unique viewpoint, but every viewpoint is inherently limited by its position. The barriers of distance, obstacles, and dangers limit all viewpoints.

The result is that people cannot see their situations and surrounding opportunities without getting information from others.

Most people have no idea how to gather information from others in order to map their potential opportunities in a useful way.

The Principle of Position

A position exists as a span of control at a specific location in a competitive environment. The elements that define a position's span of control are called mission, command, and methods.

The elements that define a position's larger environment are called the climate and the ground, which are the elements of time and place.

The potential of any position is determined by its relationship with surrounding alternative positions. Every position has both an objective reality in the physical world and a subjective reality in terms of how it is evaluated by others. Utilizing both the objective and subjective nature of positions is critical to advancing a position.

The Principle of Mission

What people do is less important than why they do it.

The actions of others can be predicted only by understanding the potential of their position in light of the motivations that sustain and drive them.

To foresee future directions, you start by categorizing the motivations that drive people in positions that affect your own.

People operate at one of three levels of motivation: physical, social, or spiritual. Physical motivations are the shortest term, while spiritual motivations are the long-lasting.

Groups and organizations are united to the degree that they share their mission and see others within the group as supporting the shared mission as opposed to their individual agendas.

The Principle of Climate

All positions are affected by forces driving change in the environment. We call these forces the competitive climate. These forces of change cannot be controlled.

Some of the resulting changes follow cycles and trends and can be predicted.

When the forces driving change can be charted, they can be used to leverage your position.

Climate exists on both the objective physical level and the subjective emotional level. Patterns of constant change strengthen or weaken positions over time.

No position is truly stable, because the changes of climate erode all positions over time.

All opportunities are created by change. The patterns of change dictate when moves should be made to advance a position.

Positions that are not advanced will gradually erode.

The Principle of Ground

All positions must be grounded in the economic reality of available resources. The ground provides those resources.

When we discuss strategy ground, we mean the ground you control and the surrounding ground, into which you may be able to move.

Changing positions is a matter of choosing your ground.

The ground is the physical component of a position, which lends it some stability over time. The minimum controlled ground is your own body.

In classical strategy, many specific conditions

affect the form and utility of the surrounding ground. Strategy teaches that there are four general types of ground, three dimensions of ground, six extreme forms of ground, and nine common ground situations.

Where and how we advance a position is dictated by the form of the surrounding ground.

Every type of ground has its own rules.

The Principle of Command

Command is the ability to make decisions affecting the control of the ground. People are constantly making decisions regarding their positions.

Everyone makes today's decisions based on what they perceive to be the future choices of others.

Competitive environments are dynamic to the degree that the people within them are free to make different choices about their positions.

People's choices are constrained by their mission, the climate, their existing ground position, and their character.

Five components determine character: intelligence, courage, trustworthiness, caring, and discipline. The decisions of individuals create the group interconnections of Methods.

The Principle of Methods

Methods are the processes that groups of people develop to work together. Methods are productive, converting the resources of the ground into assets that can be used to defend or advance a position. The methods of an individual are called skills. The methods of a group are called processes or procedures.

Advanced group processes allow individuals to develop more specialized skills. Skills and

processes create regions of internal control, protected from the chaos of the competitive environment.

This internal control allows planning, whereby skills can be organized into more effective processes.

However, methods can be evaluated only by their service to the mission.

Group processes have the potential to take on a life of their own, apart from the shared mission.

The Principle of Complementary Opposites

The world of strategy is a world of systems. Each of these systems is best understood as a balance of the opposing forces called complementary opposites.

These opposing forces create and control each other. Complementary opposites are two sides of the same system.

When people get stuck, it is usually because they only recognize or are working on half of the system. Positions are systems.

They balance control against the environment. Control shapes the environment, and the environment determines what can be controlled.

The objective and subjective nature of positions also forms a system.

Our real physical position is balanced against the subjective judgment of others about our position. Our actions shape others' opinions. Others' opinions allow our actions.

The competitive environment is a system. Ground forms the climate ,and the climate changes the ground.

Control is a system. Command chooses methods,

and methods guide command.

All challenges are systems. They balance problems and opportunities. Problems create opportunities, and opportunities generate new problems.

The Principle of Opportunity

Opportunities exist as openings in the environment that allow you to advance your position in the direction of your mission. You cannot create opportunities, as they are created by the changes in climate and the form of the ground.

You can only see the opportunities that are created in the surrounding environment.

Most opportunities are invisible because individuals lack perspective on their position and the methods to utilize available opportunities. Your choice of opportunities defines the direction of your movement.

The Principle of Creation

New opportunities are constantly created by the natural, ongoing process of change in the environment. As new methods are discovered to exploit new resources, new valuable ground is created. Classical strategy teaches that ground and climate are infinite because whole new environments are constantly being discovered or created by the forces of change.

The creation of cyberspace is only the most recent and dramatic example of the emergence of a new set of ground resources with its associated new climate. The greater the rate of change, the newer opportunities are created by expanding the environment of resources.

This rate of change is driven both by the physical climate and the psychological climate.

Rates of change are increased by the freedom of

command and the flexibility of methods.

The Principle of Destruction

Existing positions can be defended only temporarily because they are constantly degraded by change.

The same forces that create opportunities also destroy existing positions. As new resources are discovered, existing resources are devalued.

Human history is not the story of resources being exhausted but the story of new resources outmoding old ones.

Methods that try to expand control to prevent destruction also eliminate opportunities for progress.

In the long term, all such methods must themselves be destroyed by the mounting pressures of change.

Organizations do not grow indefinitely because the control demanded by their expanding internal processes eventually overwhelms their ability to use a command to adapt to change.

The Principle of Success

Success means advancing a position to better meet a mission. It is not enough simply to advance a position. The advance must also pay rewards. Since all movement requires physical, social, and spiritual resources, the reward from an advance must compensate for its costs.

Most advances yield minimal success but can position you for the few advances that can yield tremendous success. Physical, social, and spiritual costs can counterbalance one another.

Huge physical costs can engender huge spiritual rewards and vice versa. Neither the costs nor the rewards of a specific move can be predicted precisely beforehand.

The Principle of the Progress Cycle

You must complete a cycle of four steps to make any successful advance. These steps can be described as listening, aiming, moving, and claiming. If any step is missing in this cycle, no advance is possible, much less a successful advance. The Progress Cycle creates a bridge from one position to a new one.

A missing step in the cycle is like a missing span in the bridge. No matter how solid the other steps are, a single missing step renders the bridge impassible. The Progress Cycle encapsulates the scientific method for everyday decisions and actions.

The Principle of Repetition

The Progress Cycle gains power with repetition. Several quick, small advances are more powerful and unstoppable than a single big advance. The most important form of speed is cycle time: the time between the knowledge gained by listening and the claim made possible by moving. Each advance in the same direction yields more progress with less cost. Repetitions in the same direction gain power from climbing the learning curve. However, one advantage of repetition is that directions can be easily changed.

The Principle of Scalability

The Progress Cycle is a standard model both for large-scale advances (generally referred to as campaigns) and for smaller-scale advances. Each step in the Progress Cycle (listening, aiming, moving, claiming) can be broken down into several separate smaller progress cycles. This technique of breaking steps into parts is especially useful for overcoming obstacles. For example, when listening, you should first just listen. Then decide where you need to aim the conversation.

Then move to take the conversation in that

direction by making a claim. This claim sets up a new cycle of listening. Like the scientific method, the Progress Cycle is a generic model that is adapted to most specific strategic responses.

The Principle of Campaigns

Campaigns are large-scale advances in a specific direction. Campaigns are undertaken to make major readjustments in position, especially circumventing a large obstacle. Generally speaking, success in terms of a payoff is only possible at the end of a campaign.

Campaigns require a large investment of time and resources before they can be successful. This makes them inherently risky. Campaigns commonly pass through nine specific stages, each of which requires a specific response.

The Principle of Listening

Listening is necessary to gain a perspective on your situation and especially your opportunities. Most people rely on too few resources for their information. While more sources are better than fewer sources, having different types of sources is more important than having more contacts who largely share the same perspective. You need five different types of information sources for a well-rounded perspective on your position. We describe these resources as old hands, new eyes, insiders, guides, and missionaries.

The Principle of Aiming

You can move in only one direction at a time. The purpose of aiming is to find the best possible direction for the current move in light of future potential moves and to pick the right time to move.

All the paths you can choose are unique because only you can choose a path from your current position to a new position.

Your decision must be made only on the basis of potential success. Success is unpredictable because

you cannot know exactly the true costs and rewards before making any given move.

Because of this, you must be prepared for a move to fail. Therefore, most of the techniques of aiming focus on minimizing risk.

The Principle of Moving

In order to move successfully, you must immediately recognize and respond to traffic conditions. Traffic conditions are those factors that facilitate or resist movement in a given direction at a given time. All movement is controlled by the ground you must traverse and changes in climate during the move.

Only by moving can you discover the current traffic conditions. Since all routes from your current position are unique, all traffic conditions are also unique, both in place and in time.

There are nine common traffic conditions that you can encounter. Each requires a specific appropriate response.

The goal of every move is to reach the best available defendable position in the direction of the move with the minimum expenditure of resources in the fastest possible time.

The Principle of Claiming

A position cannot be rewarding unless it is claimed. Positions must be clearly claimed in order to defend them, to reap their rewards, and to use them as stepping-stones for a future advance.

The process of claiming identifies the potential, the boundaries, the ownership, and the methods for utilizing a given position. New positions must be evaluated for potential. Their boundaries must be defined. Ownership must be established. Methods for using them must be put into place.

In the end, how you communicate your claim defines the perceptions of others regarding the new position. In some situations, you want to limit information about your new position because your best defense is secrecy.

Other times, you can only get the rewards from a given position by promoting it broadly.

The Principle of Asking

Good strategy depends upon asking others for information and commitment. In controlled environments, you can plan effectively because you can control the environment. In competitive environments, competing plans collide, creating situations that no one plans.

Only by asking others what they know and what others plan, can you avoid potential conflict. Only by asking others can you win the commitments necessary to coordinate activities. The only vital weapon in strategy is the human mind.

Only by asking the right questions can you get other people's minds working for you. By definition, you cannot see these opportunities and barriers from your limited perspective. You cannot learn the terrain, identify opportunities, coordinate your movements, or make your claims without asking others for their support.

The Principle of Selective Hearing

Information is the basis for all strategies, but information depends on communication, which is a subjective process. Thoughts are not perfectly transferred to words. Words are not perfectly communicated by sound. Sounds are not perfectly interpreted by listeners.

People use words to hide and mislead as often as they use words to communicate. Communication is as much about filtering information as it is about transmitting it.

The three barriers to movement are obstacles, dangers, and distances, are also obstacles in communication, but the motivations of the speakers and listeners trump everything. When we hear the words of others, we have to consider the motivations behind them.

When we speak, we must consider what people want to hear.

The Principle of Reversal

Extreme conditions tend to reverse themselves over time. Conditions are characteristics that affect decisions. Big, small, hot, cold, fast, slow, hard, soft, dark, light, open, closed, far, near, and so on are all conditions.

Though often stated in terms of their extremes, conditions are not complementary opposites but effects that range between extremes along a continuum.

Reversal is more than regression to the mean, that is, the tendency of an extreme condition to become less extreme. Extreme conditions have a tipping point at which the extreme itself creates the opposite extreme.

For example, extreme overpopulation of an animal must eventually create an extreme depopulation of the same animal. This shift to depopulation can be caused by a depletion of food resources, an increase in predators, the spread of diseases, or other reasons.

When looking at a situation, the balancing mechanisms at work in a system (complementary opposites) are often hidden. The principle of reversal says that even when the balancing mechanism is unknown, you must suspect that it is still at work.

The Principle of Simplification

A complex array of strategic conditions can be simplified into "emptiness" and "fullness." Emptiness and fullness are the lowest common denominators of all conditions that exist along a continuum.

As we have said, big, small, hot, cold, fast, slow, hard, soft, dark, light, open, closed, far, near, and so on are all conditions that exist along a continuum.

When you simplify these ideas into emptiness and fullness, you are forced to think in terms of the underlying essences and the systems that create these conditions.

Hot and cold mean full and empty of energy. Far and near mean full and empty of travel time. Closed and open mean full and empty of barriers.

Emptiness and fullness are often seen as need and abundance.

The Principle of Inversion

Systems naturally seek to fill empty conditions and empty full ones, but the emptiness and fullness of seemingly different conditions directly invert into one another. For example, a fullness of barriers (closed) inverts into the emptiness of the ground. The emptiness of the ground inverts into the fullness of travel (speed).

The fullness of size (big) inverts into the emptiness of travel (slow).

The science of strategy defines the specific nature of these inverted relationships. Strategic leverage comes from working with this inversion force rather than against it.

The Principle of Openings

Openings are a form of emptiness that you have the resources to fill and that others will reward you for filling. These openings are a challenge. From

the perspective of emptiness, the challenge is a problem. From the perspective of fullness, the challenge is an opportunity.

Openings always exist because people always have needs (emptiness) in one area and a surplus of resources (fullness) in another area. Leverage seeks to find the proper inversion to change one into another.

The Principle of Secrecy

Ultimately, all resources exist primarily as information. An all-knowing being has infinite resources. All individuals have extremely limited resources because they have extremely limited information.

Groups have more information and therefore more resources but for any group, no matter how large, the amount of unknown information is virtually infinite.

While some leverage is gained by using secrecy to protect proprietary information, all such secrets are temporary. The larger the group that shares the secrets, the shorter its life span. The most important secrets are those that can be discovered by being the first to explore the unknown.

The Principle of Control

The least expensive way to control others is to change their perceptions and feelings. Working with subjective information is less expensive than working with physical resources. You can leverage your position by working first on the perceptions of others.

However, because of the balancing nature of systems, you must eventually reinforce subjective perceptions with objective proof of actions.

The Principle of Ease

You must make the easiest and lowest-cost move that advances your position. The path of absolute

least resistance always leads to degrading your position. However, in choosing among paths that advance your position, there is always one path that allows the most movement with the least resistance. Your progress along this path is leveraged by the opposing forces of complementary opposites seeking to rebalance conditions of emptiness and fullness.

The Principle of Less Is More

Fast, short moves are always more powerful than long, large moves. Smaller, faster groups make more progress than larger, slower groups. For every benefit of fullness, there is an opposing (though often very different) benefit of emptiness.

You create strategic leverage by putting a small amount of the right resources in exactly the right position to create the maximum advantage. The more often you can leverage the value of minimal resources, the more successful you will become.

The Principle of Momentum

Since perceptions create reality and reality creates perceptions, the least costly way to overcome resistance is by doing what is completely unexpected at a critical time. Expectations are set by consistent performance. Consistent performance is made possible by standard methods. Standards make progress predictable but unremarkable.

At a critical turning point, standard practices are abandoned and replaced with an innovative approach. Innovation alone creates surprise and can overcome specific obstacles.

Successful innovations are repeated and eventually become standard practice. Innovation and standard practices form a system of complementary opposites that, used correctly, create momentum.

The Principle of Defense

Positions that are the source of your resources must be defended. Others will challenge you for those positions to win their resources. You must defend any existing position until it becomes more profitable to abandon it.

The most important decisions in matters of defense and advance are decisions about timing. Over the long term, all positions must be advanced, but in the short term, it is often more rewarding to defend an existing position. Some positions can be advanced in minor ways without abandoning existing positions.

However, since resources are limited, old positions must often be abandoned to free up resources to develop new positions.

In every case, any existing position on which you depend for resources must be defended until those resources are better used elsewhere.

The Principle of Decision

All decisions should be made consciously and quickly. Even the decision not to act must be a choice rather than the result of indecision. You must quickly choose the best imperfect available alternative rather than waiting indefinitely for a perfect alternative.

It is better to choose non-action if all available actions are too expensive and risky. All decisions have consequences, but most people suffer much more from the consequences of indecision.

The Principle of Parsimony

You must control your costs because you can never accurately predict your rewards.

In competitive environments, neither the costs of a move nor the results of that move can be known in advance. Since many advances do not succeed, you must always retain enough resources to defend

your existing position. Each investment in an advance is a type of gamble. You can never bet more than you can afford to lose, but you must make bets in order to eventually win.

The Principle of Opportunism

A path in the right direction always exists, but you cannot know where that path leads until you try it.

Many attempted advances fail. Most successful advances yield small payoffs, but when you continually advance in the right direction, it is only a matter of time until you find yourself in the proper position to take advantage of a big opportunity.

When that opportunity arrives, it will not take the form you expect. It may not even take you in the direction that you thought you were headed. However, when you recognize such an opportunity, you must seize it and follow where it leads.

The Principle of Preparation

Rewards can be magnified with a little preparation. Preparation creates the expectations of others. You create expectations that highlight the value of your actions. You must keep secrets when the value comes from creating a surprise. You must tell secrets when the value comes from a closer relationship.

You must make clear commitments in controlled situations when the value comes from being dependable. You must avoid clear commitments in competitive situations when a specific result is unpredictable. You must let others only know enough of your plans so that they can reward you.

The Principle of Resistance

Resistance is inherent in all systems and should never be unexpected. If others know you are making a specific move, some will try to stop you. Some will try to stop you out of fear of change.

Others will try to stop you because your relative progress reflects poorly upon their lack of progress. Others will try to stop you simply because they can.

Because resistance is inherent in all systems, you try to keep your moves a secret. When you cannot keep moves a secret, make them by a route that makes resistance difficult. When such a route isn't available, prepare surprises to derail resistance when it appears.

The Principle of Adaptability

You must adapt your responses to the specifics of your situation in order to move. All situation consists of several specific conditions that are well-defined within the classical strategy (the four types of ground, the six ground forms, the nine stages, and so on). You must know the specific responses necessary to adjust to these specific conditions. You must also know how to combine these various responses to your combination of conditions. Inappropriate responses raise the cost of every move and decrease its chance of success.

The Principle of Conflict

Conflict is costly. Success is more certain when conflict is avoided. Threatening conflict is only cost-effective when it decreases the chances of actual conflict.

When conflict is unavoidable, you must control the time, place, expectations, and reports of that conflict. If you set up fights so that they are unfair, you are less likely to get involved in them.

The Principle of Recovery

Mistakes are unavoidable, but you can recover from any mistake as long as you stop repeating it. On many types of ground, many failed attempts are necessary to find a path that allows you to advance, but on each attempt, you must try something different.

The faster you can recover from a failed attempt, the quicker your progress will be. In controlled environments, the analysis of failures can prevent future. In dynamic, competitive environments, conditions change so that each attempt is a new experiment.

The Principle of Packaging

People make judgments by what they see. Packaging is a concern with outward appearances. Everyone judges a book by its cover. A good package is often as important as a good product.

A fearful-looking army is challenged less often. People judge the value of what you offer by the care spent in packaging it.

Packing influences the subjective judgments of positions. Packaging is an important part of preparing expectations.

The Principle of Attention

Getting attention, that is, overcoming indifference is the opposite of overcoming resistance. The formula for getting attention is the opposite of the formula for overcoming resistance through momentum.

To overcome indifference, you must first use surprise to win attention, and then you must use expected behavior to change attention into interest.

The Principle of Dreams

When you win a desired position, your dreams change, and new challenges arise. Life is only meaningful as long as you have new dreams to pursue.

The Principle of Fun

Using a good strategy does not ensure that every move will be successful, but it does ensure that all moves are more enjoyable.

The Principle of Happiness

Happiness comes from looking forward to your next successful move, not from looking back on your past successes.

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About Author



Prof. Dr. M. Amr Sadik, is a veteran, Practical-academic, seasoned and accomplished HR and Management senior executive with almost 4 decades with local, regional and global companies in different industries in various countries, coupled with international awards and recognitions.

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In 1997 he was nominated for Professional Excellence Award in HR from "SHRM" in USA, and in 2006 for Sheikh Rashid Bin Maktoum Award in the United Arab Emirates as the Best Arab Manager.

The Stevies Award laureate in 2007 as first Egyptian/Arab winner, and who was ranked among the top 20 HR Most International Influential Thinkers in 2014 from UK. In 2015 he received Peter F. Drucker in Management, from UOSF, Panama. Furthermore, he was ranked as one of Top 100 Thought Leader in HR and Top 25 Thought Leader in Careers by Thinker 360 in USA.

Prof. Sadik, is a regular international contributor at HR-Future magazine in South Africa, and published 4 books in India, and Germany.

He frequently called in HR conferences and summits to opine in current practices and provide his insights. In addition, he judges on several global business awards and chaired the Stevie Award HR judging panel.

As adjunct professor he is associated with various business and management schools to teach at post-graduate studies. He used to be associated with Frankfort School of Finance and Management, International Advisory Services, in Germany as HR and Training expert and Consultant.

The more you
know about the
past,
the better
prepared you are
for the future.

- Theodore Roosevelt



From history, we can learn valuable lessons. History can also serve as a warning against repeating past mistakes and as a source of inspiration for progress and innovation. Overall, learning from history help us understand the present and better prepare for the future.

Applying principles, 500 BC, from “The Art of War” by Sun Tzu to Human Resources Management can involve strategies such as understanding your team’s strengths and weaknesses, leveraging individual talents effectively, fostering collaboration, and adapting tactics to fit changing circumstances.

By applying the principles of "The Art of War" to HRM, organizations can develop more effective HR strategies, foster a positive work culture, and ultimately achieve their goals more efficiently.

Overall, the lessons from "The Art of War" continue to resonate throughout history, guiding leaders in various fields toward strategic thinking, effective leadership, and ultimately, success in their endeavors.

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